



BOTERO

BOTERO

MARCEL PAQUET

BOTERO IS THE best known and most highly regarded Latin American artist at work today. His entirely original style of painting bears correspondences to the school of Latin American writers headed by Garcia Marquez. For him the wildly imaginative is commonplace and is rendered as faithfully as one would an everyday landscape. His work is rooted in the fertile quasi-magical soil of his native Columbia.

Botero's world is an extraordinary place. His inflated figures are whimsical yet full of sorrow as they peer out on the improbabilities of the world around them, and his apparent naivete disguises penetrating cultural and political analysis. Intense and evocative, Botero's powerful work takes hold of the viewer and transforms commonly held notions about art and perception.

Marcel Paquet's penetrating study reveals hitherto unexplored facets of Botero's work. He remarks: "The painter is not someone who simply looks and who sees. Above all, the artist is someone who exposes a personal vision by rendering it visible." But the painter's quest then becomes a search for the invisible, that hidden quotient that supports the phenomenal. Botero's desire for solidity, his perception of sensuality in form, lead to an "exaggeration of the essential" and a full awareness of pictorial problems. Through Paquet's discussion of these and other significant aspects of the artist's work, the reader approaches not only finished paintings, but the creative process itself. With Botero as subject, this is an endlessly fascinating enterprise.

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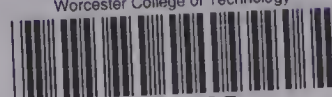
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Marcel Paquet

BOTERO

*Philosophy of the
Creative Act*

Translated by
Susan Resnick



For Raphaël, Alexandre and Hadrien

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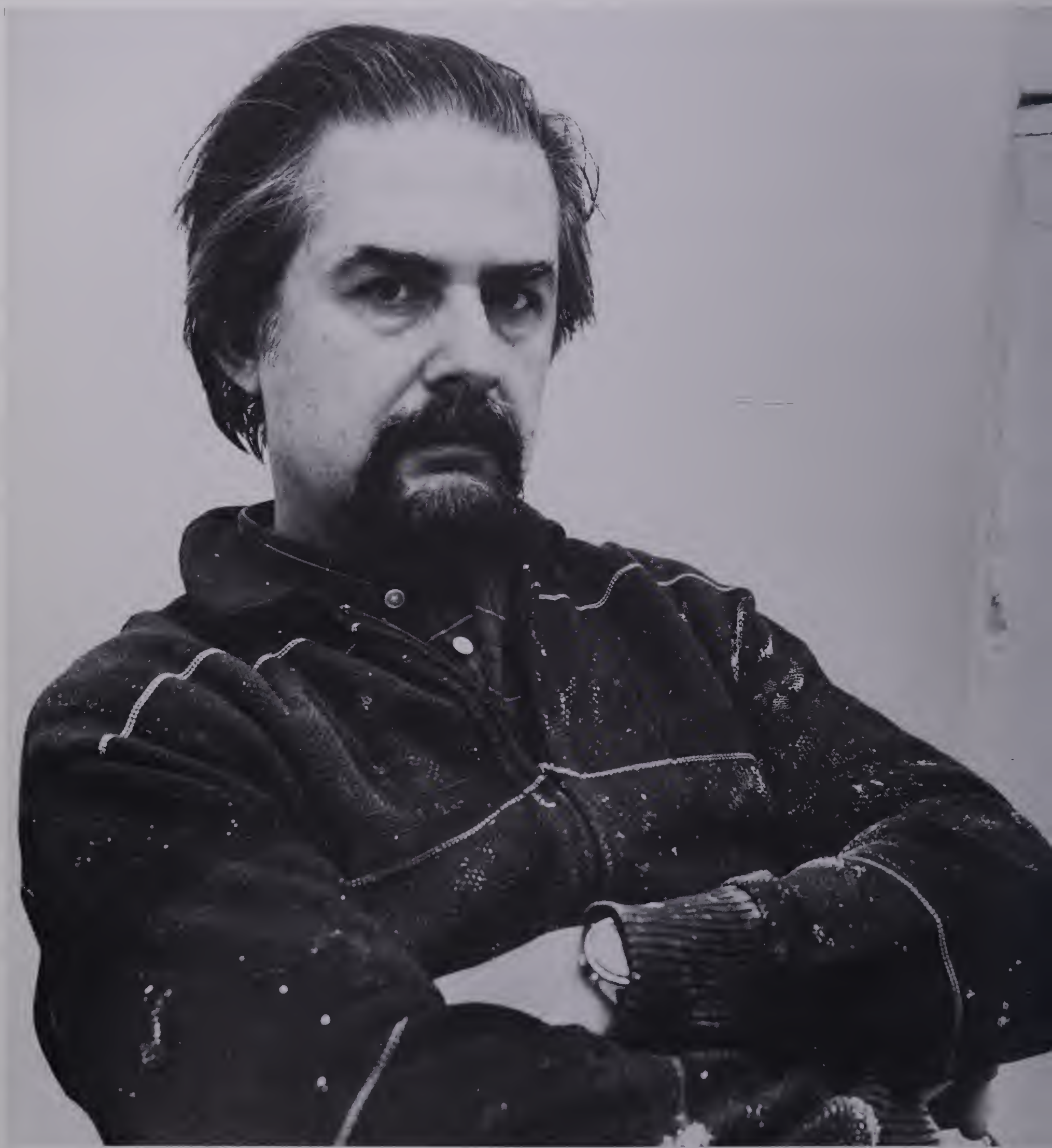
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1. Fernando Botero by Marc Trivier.

This book begins with the study of a watercolor, titled *Crying Woman*, and not with a biographical sketch of the artist, because it is our belief that only the work itself can truly convey its own intrinsic value. The watercolor is dated 1949. Botero was barely seventeen years old when he painted it. A flurry of pages could be devoted to the external factors and influences that led Botero to become an artist and sculptor, but such an approach would never lead us to the central issue. In painting, as in other areas, influences don't advance our knowledge of the subject. Hume, Rousseau, and Leibnitz didn't give us Kant. De Chirico and Magritte didn't lead to Delvaux. In order to be influenced, one must already have an existence of one's own, and be searching for "something." From the outset a work of art demands a perspective that isolates, or at least identifies, the center of the polarities that secretly or negatively orient its process. Although such an element is difficult to determine, the quest for it is necessary. Without it, all study would advance blindly not going beyond a more or less erudite descriptive level or a level of vague sentimentality. The crux of the matter in the case of painting is about starting to use one's eyes, about being initiated into the experience of contemplation. It becomes a question of relating visually to what is visible, but not only to anything visual. Painting is a visual experience par excellence because its very existence depends on being seen time and again. It exists to be contemplated indefinitely.

The painting itself foresees the perspective from which the spectator will enter into a relationship with it. When a person is about to contemplate a work of art, he or she stands in front of it, not too close and not too far away, but at a point that allows a general perspective. This in turn relays the viewer to each of the painting's parts, each brush stroke and each fragment.

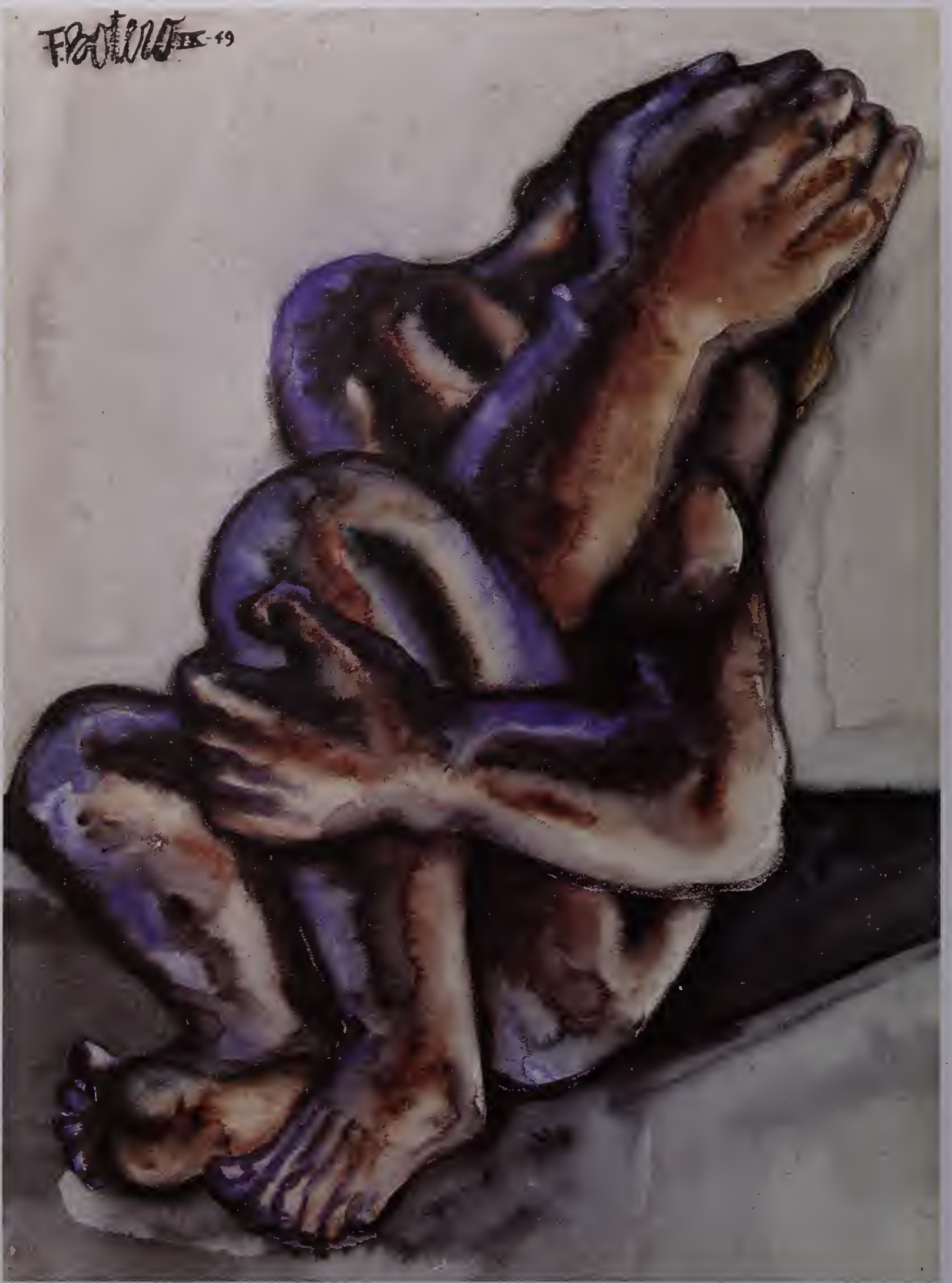
A painting is a self-contained entity defined within a framework that lends itself to a unique relationship of constraint. Kant referred to what takes place during the course of this relationship as pure contemplation. This experience is most acute with regard to painting. It is uniquely purified, extraordinarily simple, almost minimal. Despite this, or because of this, efforts to explain the experience are surprisingly resistant to formulation.

Experience and preparation are called for, since it would be futile to reach an immediate formulation. For this reason our approach is quasi empirical with regard to the impressions received from viewing *Crying Woman*. This watercolor leads us beyond the painted image towards *that* which is painted, a solid massive body that is suffering and battered. The work draws us into a sympathetic relationship with the woman who is pulling her whole being into herself. Her covered face draws her even more inward. Her contorted posture, which folds inward with a clenching intensity, is an overly concentrated gesture that is almost petrified. The magnitude of this condensation impacts on her entire naked and miserable body and gives way to an

outpouring of tears. From this emerges the expression of pain.

Crying Woman manifests the contradictory action of containment and expression. At the same instant, we are left on the threshold of suffering. We become suspended there, prisoners of the spectacle, enclosed in the distance of what is visible. Contemplation tests this distance that brings us closer to "something," which in this instance is another's pain. Distance itself is also being tested. It immobilizes us in our approach, keeps us apart from that which is only rendered present, that which never existed in flesh and blood. Direct and powerful interface with this watercolor defines the perimeters of the human condition with exceptional clarity. This interface prepares the path *towards* something without which the experience could not be brought to light. On the other hand, the work is there in the manner of a screen that stands between the phenomenon of pain and that which touches us from that pain. The painting also points us to something different within ourselves, that oscillation between what is real and what is imagined. Inherent in *Crying Woman* is another reality, which is greater than the subject itself and which it allows us to imagine. For this to happen, our imagination depends on what is perceived, the colored vision that is inscribed on the surface of a piece of paper measuring 56 centimeters by 43 centimeters. Our relying on what we perceive objectifies the work and doesn't take into account what it shows beyond itself. This is a refusal to see what the painting calls out for, what moves us. To rely on what

I
the first steps



2. *Crying Woman*, 1949. 56 x 43
cm, watercolor.



3. *Still Life with Coffee Pot*, 1965.
140 x 192 cm, oil on canvas.

is imagined by our imagination is to jump over the work, to reduce it to a means of a gratuitous enjoyment. It's a way of making the painting a mirror of ourselves or a screen on which we project ourselves.

These two untenable attitudes mutually exclude each other: Nonimaginary perception is as nonexistent as totally free imagination. To perceive an apple, we need to transgress the visible aspect that is offered. We need to make a leap of the imagination to fill in the very partial aspect that we see in order to enter into a relationship with the apple and not with an image that's totally deprived of meaning. On the other hand, we cannot just fly with a free association of images that have no relationship to other images: Even dreams are organized and oriented towards something, speak of "some thing."

Truth, therefore, is neither on the side of the perception of reality nor on the side of an imagination that is oriented towards what is unreal. Truth is in the division between the two. Both move away from one another without ceasing to be a part of each other. The work is real, but in its reality, it shows us the difference between what is real and what is unreal. It shows us a more elemental difference than the opposition between reality and unreality, a difference more elemental than the rhetorical pairing of *being* and *appearance*. We approach the being of pain through a figure of its physical expression and are condemned to our approach, condemned to skirt the borders of its intimacy. Something in this work touches us and is rendered palpable. At the same time, we experience that something is

missing, a fundamental lack, a primal, unsatisfied feeling. We identify pain. We unite with it, and sympathize with it, but this unity is missing something. It comes to us with a theoretical or substantive defect in its nature.

This is the trait that seems to best express what one might refer to as the superiority of the work of art over life. The work is not satisfied with merely separating pain from its expression, or suffering from its tears. Instead, it unites visible expression, or an image of the phenomenon with that which is necessarily lacking or missing in the image or in the phenomenon. In this way it does more than show something. It shows what is missing from what is shown, what escapes and retreats into obscurity. *Crying Woman* draws us closer to the devastation of pain. It shows us that pain can tear you apart without ripping you in pieces. Pain doesn't disperse what it hits. It maintains it in a unified way and breaks it into many parts, sustaining it within the breach between compression and expression. Pain condenses and petrifies just as much as it separates and displaces. Displacement, which in this instance is a metaphor of pain—the hand on the decayed tooth that Hans Bellmer speaks of*—doesn't wear evil down. It limits itself to attracting the viewer into a virtual vestibule. It attempts to express this in the manner of a clenched fist that forces the air out of a bag. If it's true that the expression of pain weakens the impact of pain, it also remains true that expression doesn't eliminate the totality of what it expresses. Pain itself is maintained through its expression and is protected beyond this expression. This

inward gathering of pain is the contraction of the crying body that is able to express it. Botero painted neither the tears nor the eyes. Instead, he painted an expression of pain that longed to go beyond expression. He painted an expression that denounces itself as expression, which turns towards and away from itself to ultimately rejoin that absent core of which it is the expression of expression. There is no loss of pain or any false sublimation in the movement that goes from pain to the expression of pain at the heart of which realism would refer to as "the model," and then goes from the expression of pain (tears) to the expression of expression (painted tears). What does occur is the repetition of difference, the attempt to appropriate the differential element of difference. The watercolor unifies difference, not to render a sublimated identity, but to deepen the differentiation. This is where the task of the painter lies.

Painting is not the copying of a model as is. It's the revelation of that which the model does not show. Painting is not the capture of light that's revealed when it makes contact with a dense form. It's capturing what is missing at the moment it's revealed so that it can be revealed. Painting is always going beyond the act of painting. It uses painting as a means, a path towards the unveiling of that which in felt experience is not visible.

Painting is the visible union of what is sentient and what is visible. In other words, it's the union of a difference that instead of being attenuated is intensified.

From the very beginnings of his entry into painting, Botero seems to affirm an authentic

* See our essay "Hans Bellmer, La chair et le Temps" (Ed. La Clairière, Brussels, 1979).

search. His work indicates that he wanted to confront the question of painting itself, and not merely add more canvases to the body of existing works. For this reason, it's important to emphasize what we learn from Botero's earliest paintings: They already light the way towards what will follow. It's not the path or the style that they contain, but what it should be, what it should become so that Botero exists as Botero. From the outset, we've been confronting the problem of what is sentient and what is visible, and the nature of their relationship. The visible manifestation of pain did not open a path for us towards what is nonsentient. It didn't reveal a path towards an ideal world of pure revelation and transparency.

Botero wasn't interested in painting to invent from abstraction. He wanted to clear the way towards the concreteness of that which is visible, that which the mental and the spiritual proceed from. To avoid any mistakes, let's insist on the fact that the revelation of that which is sentient is *not* the suppression of what is sentient. It is the absorption of what is sentient into a form that allows its "felt" nature along with the revelation of that "something" lacking in a revelation. Painting doesn't aspire to a miracle that would eliminate this lack. On the contrary, it attempts to freeze this lack, to solidify and petrify it. The movement of expression or of exposition is redirected *towards* that which it separates itself from. It's brought back to the principle of its beginning rather than unleashed in a reiterative manner.

Botero's painting fixes things in space. It doesn't negate their movement, but rather

turns towards that which provokes their movement. His painting goes to the very essence of mobility, to the principle of mobility. It does not get carried away by the effects of constant agitation or random scattering. The willful condensation in displacement, the willful capture in the painting of what would otherwise be purely and simply relegated to the background, is expressed *through* the painting. It is part of Botero's original intention.

That which is concrete appealed to Botero. By "concrete" we're referring to the appeal of thought and spirituality, which in themselves are not palpable except for their expression in words. It's not a matter of resorting to words to be freed from a lack of words. Likewise, the pictorial appeal of what is concrete is first and foremost the proof in images of that which is missing from the image. It is not the absurd determination to replace what is real with what is unreal, or to render an unbearable reality bearable through the imagination. Painting doesn't heal us from what is real. Nor does it relieve us from reality. In the manner of philosophical thought, it renders things heavier, more difficult and more dense. Painting apprehends things by considering that which is lacking in their revelation or in the way things are presented. In the language of Husserl, although somewhat contrary to Husserlian thought, painting presents that which is lacking in all presentation. It shows that which cannot be reduced and gives solidity to what is essentially missing from it. Solidifying the lack doesn't mean that the lack disappears, but that it's given an image!

In this way, *Crying Woman* is a painting of pain that takes into account the differentiation of pain and organizes it into a vision that *resembles* it. Painting gathers the exposition of the "Thing." It unites what is outside the self (the visible) with what supports that which is visible. It does this without implicating itself. Magritte referred to this as the act of resemblance—in other words, the adjunction to the image of the world of that which allows the world to be: *mystery*! The miracle of this adjunction relies on the fact that it operates as a subtraction or as a reduction. The painter appears to reduce into two-dimensionality that which in the real world has three dimensions, but what actually takes place is the rendering of depth that reality itself does not render. Painting doesn't create only an illusion of depth; it conquers the image of a fourth dimension. If one prefers, it shows a dimension that maintains the cohesion of the other three dimensions.

The painter does not reduce space. He exposes the principle of space. He doesn't eliminate time. He shows that which makes time work. He moves in the direction of the origin of time and space, towards the place of their differentiation, the sentient knot where they split apart. *The Dead Christ* by Mantegna does not eliminate Christ's death in favor of a transcendent truth. It gives a shortened, condensed view of the corpse, which is the surest way to expose and the best way to see the absence of life. Painting's challenge is not to clear a transcendent path, but rather a transcendental path. By this we mean an opening towards that which is hidden by phenomena, hidden by everything

that exists. The effort is to capture this obscure pole, this invisibility that is simultaneously sentient and invisible despite the paradox of its protective dissimulation. To capture the image of what is hidden beneath that which is visible is the task of painting, it's madness, its curse, the cross it has to bear, and its happiness, as well. Painting is the quest for a "beyond" that has nothing to do with salvation in the Christian sense of the word. It's a "beyond" in the here and now, definitively in

thing he was searching for, and that he would obstinately try to discover more than image in the image. He would try to make the differences that supported the image penetrate through the image, which was only a lateral derivative of it in the first place. What is valid for *Crying Woman* is valid for each of his paintings to a greater or lesser extent. The history of this deepening is the pictorial story of painting itself. The essence of painting does not exist outside of each individual



place and definitively riveted to the work itself. It's the movement of this quest that we are going to try to retrace by evoking the works of Botero. We will attempt to follow the traces of what could have been pure madness, but what instead became a work whose success has still not dispelled the incomprehension that surrounds it.

From the age of seventeen, Botero knew what he was looking for: the impossible. From that age on, he demonstrated that this was the only

painting, which contains it in a universal context. The more individual the work, the more universal it becomes, the more it instills the principles of a new singular relationship. The obligatory individuation of what is essential, which constitutes a classic difficulty of philosophy, is particularly acute with every philosophy of art. We will go into this apparent paradox at length. Without doing so, an understanding of the specific orientation that we're giving this book could not be properly understood.

4. *The Dead Christ* (Mantegna), 15th Century, 65 x 73 cm, oil on wood, Pinacoteca de Brera, Milan.



5. *Guitar*, 1959, 55 x 74 cm, oil
on canvas.

This book is not a monograph, an impossible genre in philosophy. Nor is it a logical theorization that jumps beyond the artistic phenomenon of that which is sentient *within* the work.

What is visible constitutes the field of phenomena, the field of that which reveals itself. From that which is *shown* of that which shows itself, we can induce what is shown: *being*. However, the discovery of "being" mediated by the phenomenon completely neglects the principle of obscurity that is a condition of the existence of what is visible. Without a non-negative invisibility (an underbelly of that which is sentient), without a resistant thickness, light would not encounter any obstacle. Light would thus be transparent. Transparent light is invisible by nature. Revelation or phenomenalism is possible only to the extent that the meeting between opacity and density allows what is visible to exist. From this point on, the existence of the phenomenon remains secretly conditioned by an obscurity that is impossible to capture. Existence could be interpreted in terms of appearance, the issuing forth from essence. The relationship between existence and essence, between the exterior world and the interior world, is absolutely dependent on the principle of visibility. Visibility itself is secretly dependent on the principle of density or opacity. The difference between what is visible and what is sentient is nonvisible and nonexistent. When it comes out of itself, it's always through the mediation of "Another," and it always happens in an oblique way. From this moment, all that exists, what we call nature, exists and reveals the essence of its

existence only by masking "density." The word *density*, the spelling of which we will discuss further on, refers not to that which is revealed, but to that which permits revelation to occur. All that is visible conceals "something." It doesn't conceal in the same way a mask hides a face, but in the way a face itself conceals. The skin conceals more than it reveals! Henceforth, all efforts to be objective unfold in the deceptive world of phenomena, a world whose principle of clarity and light is entirely supported by its total opposite. Identity is always identity of self and what is different from self. In a deeper sense, difference never ceases to maintain itself in the recesses of identity. Difference is always difference within the dialectics of difference and identity. It does not identify with itself, and is self-contained only to the extent that it separates from that which conditions it from within and from without.

Identity only achieves its worldly ideal of unifying principles in a center by ejecting the shadow principle (the principle of concealment) out of the center. This principle darkens in proportion to the strength, clarity, independence and particularity of the work whose identity it opposes. By pushing the play of particularized identity to its limit, one goes one's own limit; the logic of identity is the most solidly opposed, and art, which retains identity *within* difference, has the greatest impact. Painting does not content itself with showing the surface of things. It also shows that it conceals *more* than it reveals, and at the same moment, it reveals that it intends to show it. The more a painting unites the op-



6. *Still Life with Musical Instruments*, 1959, 140 x 188 cm, oil on canvas.



position of clarity and shadow into its expression, the more what is concealed is *like* a shadow principle of the work. The difference between what is visible and what is sentient is not eliminated when the two identify with each other in the painting. Difference is assembled in an individuated whole, whose perpetual radiance depends on the extent to which sentience is condensed. The more the work achieves the union of what is visible and what is invisible, the more the invisible attracts it, works at it from within, and makes itself felt. Painting doesn't exist as painting without this experience of the arrival of the density* of what is sentient into what is visible. Every authentic artist experiences this calling, this ascension into the work of what he's searching for and doesn't know. All true artists experience in their necessarily singular ways the effect of this mobility of principles that we've just formally summarized and that we must now espouse *in concrete form*. Otherwise stated, there's a moment when the density of sentience turns towards the work itself. It's a moment when all conscious research, all that is technique and willfulness in the work coincides with a desire that comes from somewhere else. It's a pulse that comes from a depth greater than human depth. From the moment it's experienced, it leads the mortal artist beyond himself. Botero had this decisive experience in Mexico in 1956. The artist spoke of the experience to Carter Ratcliff in the following terms: "It was a day when I was completely exhausted. There was a piece of paper in front of me. I was holding a pencil at the tip. I made a small mark in the middle of

7. *Trombone Player*, 1982, 189 x 97 cm, oil on canvas.

* More will be said on the spelling of this word.

a mandolin that I had sketched and when I looked at the paper, I said to myself: My God, this object is monumental; its plasticity is enormous.”*

Still Life with Mandolin (dated 1956) and *Still Life with Musical Instruments* (dated 1959) represent this modification that would lead Botero towards his definitive style, his own way of making his mark in painting. At the time of this experience, Botero was doing research in the area of cubism with its pictorial determination to transcend the classical point of view in painting. The central issue for cubism was to take into account the volume of things, to look at objects as three-dimensional and not as flat figures. The Cubists, Braque and Picasso in particular, had made “*volume in painting*”† their “cause celebre.” It was a matter of embracing an object from a multiplicity of sides from which came the object’s volume. It involved turning around the object in an imaginary way. Indeed, it’s quite clear that a real displacement around an object would be of no usefulness in terms of total possession by the eye, since the eye in a real rotating movement would never encode more than one side at a time. Max Loreau was right when he wrote of Picasso being led to conceive that “the object in painting is like an imaginary sculpture,” like the result of the movement of the eye as it looks at the object. The eye revolves around the object, but the outcome is nonetheless unreal, exclusively mental. Wanting to seize the object from an inner perspective, a perspective that comes from within the object ‘itself and not from outside, cubism not only unsettled the essence of paint-



8. *Family Scene*, 1967, 187 x 115 cm, oil on canvas.

* Rateliff, C., *Botero* (NY: Abbeville Press, Inc., 1980), p. 42.

† Cf. the excellent article by Max Loreau: “Picasso, Volume in Painting” (*Poésie*, Number 5), p. 46.



9. *Still Life*, 1983, 178 x 135 cm,
oil on canvas.



10. *Rich Kids*, 1966, 198 x 193 cm,
oil on canvas.

ing, but above all gave credence to the possibility of a pictorial object that was purely conceptual. Without delving into the consequences of this increasingly accentuated retreat into perception, we can take note of Botero's originality in this particular context. The objects in these two still lifes fit quite well into the interplay of moving objects. The interplay testifies to the sources of unreality that painting draws from. The main shock, however, stems from the internal handling of the mandolin, which increases in volume without ceasing to be perceived as something identifiable. In these canvases, Botero seems to espouse the finality of cubism (the acknowledgement of volume), but he doesn't get carried away by the abstract consequences of this approach. He stops midway, at the point where this style of investigation still coincides with an eye that is more corporeal than mental. Botero keeps a middle ground between what is perceived and what is imagined. He combines a face-to-face vision of things with a reflective relationship. He takes into account the reflection of the thing in the organic eye and considers this reflection, modifying it only to the extent that is compatible with maintaining a relative amount of classical pictorial figuration. He combines the unique point of view on the object with perspective, which is not possible in the classical sense: volume. Otherwise stated, Botero is at the very heart of the issue of painting without adhering either to an intellectual ideal of ensconcing himself in the trends of contemporary art. He shows the object; he gives us a representation of it, but

from a certain angle, this representation integrates the invisible condition of what is visible. What is sentient is approached in its purity and in its density.

We've coined the word *density* to address a dimension of things that cannot be captured. The "within" that it designates cannot be dialectically articulated with its "without" or exterior. It remains that inner part that is never manifest, except in an oblique way, by the dance of thought (Nietzsche) or by an exclusively visible idea (Magritte).^{*} Henceforth, when Botero related his fundamental experience, it's surprising that it never occurred to him that he had succeeded in carving out a niche for himself at the very center of Cubist investigations. He didn't think he had solved a problem inherited from Braque or Picasso. He thought instead that he had solved a problem stemming from painting in its most traditional context, an age-old problem, something that couldn't be dated. The word he used to describe what occurred was *plasticity*. It's thus the meaning of this word that we will focus our attention on. This will be the path that will allow us to understand Botero's originality, that which allowed him from his modernity to engage in dialogue with the summits of painting, in particular the Quattrocento. Plasticity designates what is relative to modeling, that which gives form to a substance. Plasticity doesn't consider form for form's sake in the manner of a rigid contour or a hollow envelope. It considers form as tied to a force that brings it into existence. Plasticity concerns the "natural aspect" of form, in the classical Greek sense, inso-

much as it results from a genetic principle. For the Greeks, nature was not the objective correlative of mathematical laws invented by a self-conscious subjectivity. Instead, they thought of nature as an animate, living principle capable of espousing its material *from within*. When understood from this angle, the imitation of nature no longer means the reproduction of already dead models, such as the "still life," which from French is literally translated as "dead nature" (*nature morte*), but rather the notion of "silent lives." Plasticity designates nonabstract form, the relationship between form and that which form is a form of. The principle that governs the works of Botero can be found at the heart of this relationship.

^{*} Cf. our essay "Magritte or the Eclipse of Being" (Ed. de la Différence, Paris 1982); Cf. also: *Botero, the Fullness of Form*, idem, 1983.

Earlier essays have already allowed us to unearth certain traits that, *mutatis mutandis*, we find in each of the works of Botero. Of major importance among these traits is his desire for *solidity*. From the outset Botero was searching for something solid in his paintings, something that would endure. He not only sought this in his choice of materials, which had to resist the wear and tear of use and time (a work of art cannot seek what is ephemeral as its end goal), but also as a concept. Solidity is a metaphysical concept as well as a physical notion. A solid base offers sure footing, a basis for establishing something. In order for a painted work to be solid, it has to render the possibility of seeing in a way that prior to it did not exist.

The painter is not simply someone who looks and who sees. Above all, the artist is someone who exposes a personal vision by rendering it visible. The painter shows or allows the seeing of "something" that without him, without his intervention, would not be seen. He manifests through his work a possibility of seeing that would otherwise remain latent. In other words, painting is an art that reveals or unveils the world from an angle that the world itself does not present to us. Painting creates. It does not limit itself to imitation or reproduction. Any desire to confine painting within the limits of *déjà vu* would be a gross misunderstanding of the essence of what painting is. Painting allows us to see that which without it would never be seen. It also makes it possible to clarify this "more," this surplus of vision that depends on the

painted work for its being in the world.

The surplus of vision that characterizes the pictorial eye is no mere accident or circumstantial outcome. Nor is it a monstrous or explainable deformation. Quite the contrary! If such a surplus did not exist, all of reality would collapse. For that matter reality couldn't even exist. Reality could not exist and endure without the support of that which is sentient. Approached in its purity, sentience designates the possibility the world and things have to exist, to be manifest. Sentience in itself is never tested. The experience of sentience is always causal. It's always a sensorial experience, be it tactile, olfactory, auditory, related to the sense of taste, or, more specifically for our purposes, visible. The visibility of what is sentient only exists as visibility if it offers resistance to the propagation of light. Without the invisible opacity of mass or volume there could not be visibility. Henceforth, the problem of painting is not to reproduce what is visible, but to produce visibility that is enriched by what is invisible, i.e., sentient.

The painter's task is to show that which exceeds the visible, to render the inside of sentience, what we have called the dansity of sentience. The rendering of dansity in images in no way eliminates dansity's existence within its own recesses. It merely gives it access, a means of being accounted for. Painting is the visible path towards what is sentient. This path, which Botero evokes when he speaks of the "creation of sensuality through form,"* can never be erased by that onto which it opens. The path that leads to the end of contemplation

II solidity and plasticity

* Arciniegas, Germán, *Fernando Botero* (NY: Harry N. Abrams, Inc. and NJ: Edilerner International, 1977), p. 51.



11. *Still Life with Flower Vase*,
1963, 180 x 180 cm, oil on
canvas.



12. *The Grandmother*, 1982, 195 x 146 cm, oil on canvas.

could never be deduced. To make such a deduction would bring us back to square one with nothing to see but the blinding white surface of the canvas. We'd be confronted with an blank indication. The path that leads towards sentience moves hand in hand with pictorial visibility, the visibility of the work of art. Painting unites what is sentient with what is visible in the visible. Without the presence of sentience at the heart of what is visible, the canvas would have no traits, nothing to hold our attention, nothing that makes us look at it over and over again, nothing that leads us to contemplate it indefinitely. This hidden dimension of the painting provides the work with its main force of attraction. Moreover, it's this dimension of unreality, more profound than reality, that the painter gives form to. He confers on it the body of his images.

Prior to the painting, this dimension doesn't exist as a model to be reproduced. Realism is only apparent in painting because reality is never part of painting's criteria. Painting is solid only if it transcends reality, if it fixes itself on that which supports reality, that which renders reality possible. For this reason, the reality of a painting is a strange thing. Nonetheless, the moment it's damaged, altered, or deformed, it loses all potential to be approached in its essence. With this in mind, Botero attempted to avoid having his work misinterpreted as psycho-scientific or realistic perception when he declared: "My ideas on art transform reality, which is my subject. The forms expressed in my paintings are the result of my ideas and not of some ocular defect. I insist on em-

phasizing this point, because five or six centuries from now I don't want people to be saying with regard to me what they're saying today with regard to El Greco."*

The solidity of painting is part and parcel of the painting's ability to capture that which is beneath the visible in a tangible form, that which could never become manifest, even obliquely, without art. The density of what is sentient cannot be felt. On the other hand density can only be part of felt experience. It is invincibly resistant to the inner-outer dialectic. Sentient density is like the totally transparent "Other," like the "Other" in thought that incessantly fails to conceive the "Other" and incessantly begins anew because it refuses to admit failure. To think is to build a path towards what is sentient. Painting is also a means of building a path towards sentience, but it is an exclusively visible path, a path built with brush strokes and colors. The painter organizes the opening to what is sentient from the very center of what is visible, and he never departs from this visible center. He builds a window that looks out into the beyond of what is visible, which looks out onto that which conditions what is visible. In exposing itself, the painting also exposes that which escapes it, that which remains hidden. This doesn't mean that painting eliminates the existence of what is sentient. It means only that it takes into account this dimension that rebels against man's attempts to capture it. We cannot repeat often enough that painting is a path. The path is different each time, although each time it gravitates towards the same mystery, the same obscurity. It's a path

* Arciniegas, G., *Botero*, p. 51.

that is constantly confronted with its endlessness. It's a path hurtling against the impossible, but which also inscribes this impossibility within itself and takes sustenance from it.

Of all the great Renaissance artists, Andrea Mantegna was perhaps the one who more than all others inscribed in his paintings the resistance of what is sentient to that which is visible. Mantegna was a painter of solidity, if ever there was one. He gives his canvases an air of heaviness: His subjects have the weight and hardness of stone. Mantegna was attached to that which resisted the erosion of the centuries. He focused on what would last, what could travel through time without being carried away by time. Thus, Mantegna never targeted the historical event, but instead the archaeological site that rendered the event possible. It's quite remarkable that, on the northern wall of the master bedroom (*Camera degli Sposi*) of the Gonzaga Ducal Palace, Mantegna has assembled about twenty people in a fresco for an event that to this day cannot be determined.

This is due not only to the absence of documents or to a lack of historical knowledge. It seems to have been a deliberate gesture on Mantegna's part. He appears to have astutely put the event into a state of suspension. Not one person is rendered in hierarchical fashion. He captures the whole of the Court in its everyday likeness. What is eternal in this fresco is life itself, the way life is at any given moment, the day-in-and-day-out aspect of life. The beauty of this work resides in its truthfulness, not in its small embellishments. It resides in

the petrifying presence of infinity at the heart of what is finite. Transcending the ephemeral and historical in favor of that which is eternal, the apparition of infinity renders the ordinary world ridiculous and accentuates the impression of mortality to the point of anguish. Mantegna's awareness and assumption of human decay made it possible for him to allow the infinite to impose and fix itself in spite of time's passage. In the course of his many study trips throughout Italy, Botero stopped in Mantua and visited the *Camera degli Sposi*. He stood before the northern wall that's described above. He rendered his own version of the Mantegna fresco, and in doing so, he not only educated and enlightened us about Mantegna but also afforded us valuable insights into his own pictorial path as well.

A whole network of differences appear between Mantegna's work and Botero's interpretation of it. Botero seems to have abandoned the aspect of the "court assemblage" in favor of a more familial dimension. One could say that he neglected the aristocratic aspect of the fresco in favor of the physical characteristics of the people: prominent noses and double chins, for instance. He also reduced the number of people to six, all of whom are members of the Gonzaga family. Among those he eliminated from his painting was Marsilio Andreasi, the secretary to Ludovico III. As a result, the Duke no longer pivots to the right and is seen only in profile, where we see the characteristic traits of the ducal family. The inbred nature of the characters are of prime importance in Botero's work. The dwarfed daughter of the



Gonzagas loses the monstrous side of her portrayal and is more harmoniously integrated into the group. Botero has even arranged the painting in such a way that the girl appears taller than her sister, who is holding an apple in her hand. Botero concentrates on the faces in his canvas and on what these faces have in common. The negative effect of this concentration on faces is the near-total suppression of background and the elimination of all other characters except for the Gonzagas. The positive effect, however, comes from the fact that the faces that occupy nearly the entirety of the canvas seem to engender the space on the canvas, as opposed to the canvas engendering and containing the faces. Space has a tangible effect in the paintings of Botero. It's not something that exists prior to and contains what is sentient. This inscription in pictorial visibility of the sentient origins of space is only being touched upon at this particular stage, but we will see that it is a decisive characteristic in all Botero's work. We'll examine the numerous consequences of this principle later in our study. At present, it's pertinent to note that Botero's simplification of Mantegna's composition in no way eliminates the difficulties of painting. With Botero these difficulties just become more evidently pictorial.

To borrow an expression from Van Gogh, one could say that Botero "exaggerates what's essential" by referring the issue of the figuration of the Gonzagas to the issue of their presentation in painting. Botero's rendering of the Gonzagas was thus in no way gratuitous. It dealt with the pictorial problem their figuration imposed. What was true

13. *La camera degli sposi* (Mantegna, detail from the North Wall). 16th century, Palazzo Ducale, Mantua.
14. *Homage to Mantegna I*, 1958, 170 x 201 cm, oil on canvas.

of Mantegna's work becomes even more explicit in the work of Botero. The message that Ludovico III holds in his hand can no longer be imagined as a letter from the Vatican or as anything else for that matter, because it becomes the very title of Botero's work: *Homage to Mantegna*. The title reveals a profound truth with regard to the fresco: It's a masterpiece of painting erected to glorify painting and not to glorify those who commissioned it. In the way he viewed Mantegna, Botero accentuated and liberated painting to deal with all subjects in an egalitarian manner. The dog, an excellent example of Botero's prodigious bestiary, is no less important than Ludovico III or his wife, Barbara de Hohenzollern. It can thus be said that Botero was not limited to copying Mantegna in order to understand him. Nor did he interpret Mantegna merely out of admiration for him. Botero was also attempting to resolve the same problem that Mantegna had tackled by using different means. To do this he isolated the problem and put it on center stage. The connection between Botero and Mantegna is not one of influence or affiliation, and it would be absurd to look at the dwarf in the *Camera degli Sposi* as the source of "Boteromorphism." The real connection lies in fraternization, two painters dealing with the infinity of a single problem that offers multiple solutions.

Great painters like great thinkers are like the stars in the sky. They shine above us and follow their individual paths, each in his or her own way. The affinity between them is one of difference and singularity. They don't communicate among themselves with the same coin. They don't

circulate the same message. They simply communicate through their return to the source of all exchange, through the depth of the mystery that grips them and allows them to transcend the structures of history. Painting is Mantegna wrapping his subjects in the hardness of that which resists what is visible, but it's also Botero trying to make insubordinate sentience visible by rendering form as the origin of space.

We've seen that Botero dealt with the question of the *Camera degli Sposi* by giving attention to the faces. The face is the outside where the inside makes itself visible, but it is also the place where the density of sentience is most concealed. Because the face reveals something, it makes us forget that it conceals much more than it reveals. This is what happens in Botero's version of Mantegna. The forgotten part of vision returns to the same place that was generally devoted to its oblivion. When Botero polarized all his attention on the Gonzaga faces, and included the face of the dog, as well, the thickness of sentience comes from within to cause form. These faces are figures for the entire body in addition to being the outside of the heads they conceal and reveal. The presence of what is sentient is condensed into these faces that Mantegna had made manifest through the hardness of stone. If indeed the issue is the same for both artists, and if in each case it's a matter of showing what is sentient despite its invisible nature, then the angle chosen by Mantegna and that one sustained by Botero differ in every respect. With Mantegna the limit of what is visible is marked by an enveloping ri-





gidity. With Botero the limit of what is visible tends to compensate itself by thrusting what is sentient into the heart of form. Instead of battling with closed contours, Botero's thrust seems to work at form with gentleness and good humor. One might say that, with Botero, the visible is allowed to move and be modeled instead of being frozen within its own limitations. Although Botero captures Mantegna's fresco from a very specific angle, Botero was still able to reach what was essential in the painting: He revealed more than what was visible.

To reveal more than what is visible is to expand what is visible. This action would not be possible if what was visible was objective reality and had a determined essence. This is not the case, however. What is visible is possible. However, what is possible is not real. It's unreal. To explore a reality is not to inspect or scrutinize it. The unreality of painting makes it possible for Botero to have lunch with Piero della Francesca and Ingres, despite the fact that the reality of time and death make this encounter impossible in reality. Botero played with this unreality, and was able to achieve through the image what would have been impossible to achieve in reality. We mustn't, however, lose sight of the fact that what is achieved in images or in painting is not only the narration of a desire that reality renders inaccessible but also the very concrete pictorial realization of pictorial possibility.

The encounter between two painters has nothing in common with normal human encounters. The encounter between two painters can only happen through painting. As a





16. *Dinner with Ingres and Piero della Francesca*, 1972, 163 x 188 cm, charcoal on canvas.

matter of fact, Botero met Piero della Francesca one night in Madrid while he was wandering in the street. The window of a bookstore was lit. Botero approached the window and in an open book saw a reproduction of *The Queen of Sheba's Visit to King Solomon*. It produced a shock effect in Botero comparable to the one experienced by Magritte when he saw Giorgio de Chirico's *Love Song*. Botero discovered painting for the first time. It's not that he didn't already know about painting, since he had copied Titian and Velasquez at the Prado. Yet something in that particular painting allowed him to see what he would henceforth continue searching for. The painting of Piero della Francesca may shed some light on our understanding of the questions we've asked in connection with Botero and Mantegna regarding communication between painters.

Piero della Francesca, master among the masters, unites the most monumental and majestic with the most delicate and graceful. Without losing any of the prodigious force that characterizes his hierarchical figures, he conferred the greatest solidity on the most simple and humble of gestures. Architectural marbles, lush textured fabrics, the uniting of bodies to form a container for the contact of naked hands. An impression of something sacred emanates from the hands of the Queen of Sheba and King Solomon and draws everything around it towards their center. Where Mantegna is painful and rigid, Piero della Francesca is able to show himself tender and silent. With him, solidity is not only the death of the finite, but infinite life and the joys of the mind. Botero was touch-

ed by this joy, and took on his task.

The joy in painting is sensitive to the body, but it's not an ordinary pleasure. It's a postponed gratification whose sole object is its form. The finality of this pleasure is endless, and can only be manifested in what is possible, and takes place only in unreality or in the absence of place. The site of painting is unreal, spiritual. It's like something that's missing in the bosom of reality. It's an absence that can't be filled, a netherworld that is unattainable. To give form to this loss is to show that this loss is felt or to reveal that it is concealed. It is revealed by something that is absent when it becomes part of the representation of the hands of King Solomon and his Queen, but is not eliminated as an absence. Quite to the contrary, absence is brought to the highest intensity. There's something missing in sentience that addresses itself to man's senses and leads him to create that which he could never discover. Man is a metaphysical animal in the sense that he has notions, or makes up images of that which he can't feel in what is tangible. By painting what is tangible, by giving what is sentient a body of images made from lines and colors, the painter renders visible the dimension of what is sentient that sentience alone is unable to reveal. The painter responds to the call of what is missing, what can only become manifest in the painting. The life of the artist unfolds in the realm of what is possible, or sentient, in the realm in which reality originates, the place from which everything human in the world is engendered. The painter travels through what is sentient to bring back to the sur-



17. *The Dance*, 1980, 41 x 33 cm,
oil on paper.

18. *The House of Rachel Vega*,
1975, 195 x 246 cm, oil on
canvas.









20. *The Visit of the Queen of Sheba to King Solomon* (The Story of the Real Cross), 15th Century, fresco, The Church of San Francesco, Arezzo.



face of what is visible something that sentience could not engender by itself. What the painter renders visible, therefore, adds “something” to what is sentient. Once again, painting is a metaphysical act. In nature or in the physical world, metaphysics and meaning are absent.

Metaphysics emanates from the experience of this absence, from the experience of a lack. Experiencing this lack doesn’t eliminate the lack, but instead allows it to exist as a lack. It gives what is lacking a place to make a mark, to make its absence felt. What is possible is always missing from what is real. Reality’s temptation is to transform what is possible into a higher reality, another reality. The creative act is something else. It maintains what is possible as possible, and doesn’t reduce it to a condition of reality. It allows what is possible to be what is possible and calmly paints it. Staying within the work of what is possible means cutting oneself off from reality. There is always a risk of madness, of mental isolation.

Botero wasn’t immune to this risk. There was always the threat of being cornered in a situation where he would be the only one to understand himself. He continued to paint, nonetheless, and successfully imposed his possibility on reality. It wasn’t like realizing a possibility in the sense that this possibility would eliminate itself as a possibility and blend into reality. To impose a possibility on reality is to force reality into looking beyond itself, to force it to admit that it’s lacking something, and obliging it to turn towards that which it is lacking, that which shines forth from the painting of the joined hands at the center of *The Queen of*



22. *The Fall of the Oranges*, 1982,
156 x 112 cm, oil on canvas.



23. *The Waterfall*, 1982, 167 x 112
cm, oil on canvas.

Sheba's Visit to King Solomon. Botero was touched by this marvel of equilibrium and mystery, by this miracle of strength and simplicity. He was drawn to the absent center of the painting, towards what was always virtual but never there, except in painting.

It's through this approach that painters have a silent communication with each other. They admire and critique each other at the core of what is visible, each one knowing that none can get to that "far beyond" that they all want to reach. There are multiple paths, an infinity of paths available in the realm of what is possible, and yet each painter knows that only one is open to him—his own. This is the price to be paid for "stardom" in the constellation of great painters. It's for this reason that Mantegna and Piero della Francesca, if considered to be models of affinity for Botero's research, must also be seen as the instruments that Botero intends to assimilate, while keeping one eye focused on what makes them different.

What is meant by Botero's referring to Mantegna and Piero della Francesca with an eye focused on their difference merits explanation. Painters consider each other in the same way that great writers do: They read each other's work to avoid imitating one another and to communicate more through difference than through identity. The praises that they bestow on each other are always only half sincere, because without the desire to do better work and to understand the other painter better than he or she understands himself or herself, there would be no need to become a painter.

Without this desire, it would suffice to remain a spectator. The painter, however, is not someone who can be content to merely see something. He can't limit himself to a prescribed point of view. He wants to see everything, including what's behind his back. The eye of a painter is an eye that wants to gather everything onto the canvas—not only that which presents itself as the painter walks through cities and countryside or visits museums and churches, but that which does not present itself. Above all, the painter wants to encompass all that which he cannot see. The dream of every painter is to see with an "unblinded eye," a naked eye. If the painter's canvas is a flat surface, the back of which has no relevance, it's because the vision that's inscribed on the front surface is assumed to be a vision that reveals what's behind it in a forthright manner. More precisely, it's a vision that reveals even that which it conceals. Painting not only sees something, but it sees something with vision and inscribes within it the possibility of vision as a reservoir, of visibility. This reservoir which enables the painting to be seen time and time again, is identical to the painting only in terms of "esthetics," in terms of the eye of the beholder. The painter's eye is an eye that is traversed by the difference between what is seen and what is visible. Paintings appear to the artistic vision like entities that are worked upon by this difference, like a variety of opportunities for sorting out what is revealed and what is concealed. To the extent that what is visible as such is never seen, a painter looks at the works of other painters as if they were only

halfway successful, as if they needed to be reworked in a different way.

For those of us who are not painters, the difference between Mantegna and Piero della Francesca is between two identities, between two ways of inscribing what is visible into a vision. Where Mantegna arrives at an auto-negation of sentience that stratifies his subjects in the rigidity of their mortal fate, Piero della Francesca, through the sublimely undiscernible of color and line, transforms the concealment of what is sentient into an apparition of the Spirit. With Piero della Francesca the invisible obscurity of what is sentient emerges into the light. That which is lacking shines forth like plenitude. His work not only reveals the death of that which is finite. They reveal an inorganic or spiritual life, as well.

The life of a painting is different than life as we know it. No one can eat a painted apple. A painting doesn't augur the resurrection of bodies, either. It is simply a life that makes life possible for a thinking, feeling human being capable of experiencing ecstasy or transcendence in the here and now.

A human being perceives as well as sees the images of things: He sees them *be*. What he sees is inscribed as a revelation of being that is concealed as being in that which obliquely reveals it. To think is to go from that *which is revealed* towards that which is revealed *and* which is more and different than the pure and simple projection of the thing in light. "More" is the only true subject that painting addresses. It has no model, and therefore, just about everything could be "it" once liberated onto the canvas. The



24. *Sunflowers*, 1967, 194 x 197
cm, oil on canvas.

painter transforms his subject when he transposes it, but this transposition is not a loss in its being or a lessening of the copy in relationship to its original. It's more like a template of the original, a use of the original that uses the original to give light to what the original is not, to what it conceals. Painting is art only if it integrates this transcendental dimension, if, over and beyond the relationship between the one who sees and what is seen, it involves an opening in which this secondary relationship is formed. In the stage that precedes this relationship, the work of art has within it the possibility of subverting the realistic model of what is possible, which today we refer to as the subject-object relationship.

An "object" that includes in itself the revelation of its origin or the signs of its possibility is not an object. To be sure, the phenomenology of a work of art provides a grasp on subjectivity. Kant was acutely aware that this was a question of taste and not erudition, a matter of thought and not of knowledge. Beauty is always a transcendental path towards the thing itself, but is never itself an object. This path is not contradictory to logic. It is totally different. In our eyes, this is part of painting. Botero's vases of flowers are a case in point. It's not so much the variation in the Flemish tradition that strikes us. Nor is it the violence in their enlargement, like in Van Gogh's sunflowers. What's most striking is the painting's overabundance of inner strength. The tightly stuffed flowers seem to dream of escaping from the vase that contains them. There's something in them that makes it difficult for them to deal with the con-



25. *The Sunflowers* (Van Gogh), 1887, oil on canvas, Stadtgalerie, Munich.



text of their presentation. Their volume contrasts with their encircling container and doesn't tolerate being flattened. With Botero this contrast doesn't degenerate into open conflict like the forms and cubes do in Bacon's works. Instead, they are organized in a way that allows them to bloom with so much vivacity and intensity that their full bloom had to be captured in the flatness of space. Botero is not avoiding the struggle between what is sentient and what is visible, but instead of cultivating the struggle for its own sake, he uses it solely in terms of beauty.

Not only is what underlies the mystery of worldly things beautiful but also that which makes this mystery emerge. A thing of beauty is beautiful in itself as a thing *and* as beauty. Painting is phenomenological. To paint is to make visible the enriched reality of that which is unreal, that which is possible, that which has no status in reality. Magritte expressed this in one of the vigorous and splendid formulas he had the key to: "Meaning is Impossible."

The great theoreticians of the Renaissance, Alberti and Vinci, were expressing the same things when they called "depth" the pictorial impossibility par excellence. What's troublesome in the Renaissance appellation is that it was analyzed in terms of objectivity, in terms of a humanistic conception of things. Despite this fact, it conveyed that the essential and precise bidimensionality of the canvas (although always deprived of the third dimension that characterizes things) not only extends into space and is measurable, but resists it, is endowed with its own dynam-

26. *Rosalba*, 1979, 193 x 126 cm, oil on canvas.



27. *Vase with Flowers*, 1979, 192
x 154 cm, oil on canvas.



28. *Musician*, 1983, 195 x 117 cm,
oil on canvas.

ics. This inner vitality defined movement for the ancient Greeks, and gravity for moderns like Newton. Let's, however, stay within the confines of painting!

Painting doesn't present its "object" or "model" in flesh and blood. It is content to present, somewhat in the manner of a geometry teacher who, using a chalk-drawn form that in and of itself is only a schematic tool, presents the real subject of the demonstration, to illustrate the law of a perfect circle as a mathematical definition. If painted forms were allied to mathematics, the defect of being too thick or too material would come through. Giacometti was amused by this when he pointed it out to Mondrian. Beauty, if not a matter of perfection, is certainly far from being a defect. The lack of conformity with regard to that which a form is a form of, allows painting to do something much better than deceive the eye or to render an image that lacks depth. The absence of conformity stems from the unreality that is part of the work and that enables it to be part of all that which goes beyond height, width, and depth. In cutting off from reality to benefit that which is possible, the painting can put itself in the serenity of what the Cubists referred to as "the inner perspective."

Botero was expelled from his high school in Colombia for an article he wrote on Picasso, for having been touched by the passion of revelation that involves revealing more than what is socially acceptable. It's important to reiterate that Botero disassociated himself from Cubism and Surrealism early on, although paintings such as *Still Life with Guitar*, a cubist work, or *Woman Cap-*



29. *The House of Mariaduque*, 1970, 180 x 185 cm, oil on canvas.

tured by a Demon, a surrealist work, belong to those movements. From the moment he arrived in Paris, Botero preferred the Louvre and Egyptian art to the exhibitions of his contemporaries. He also preferred Italy to Paris: Masaccio, Uccello, Piero della Francesca, Mantegna, Giorgione, and so many others. Nonetheless, Botero's love for the fifteenth-century Italian painting (Quattrocento) is a fiercely modern love. His adherence to this tradition was authentic and wasn't based on zeal, erudition, or copying. He adhered in a creative way, discovered the possibilities contained in these paintings that had not been exploited. *Homage to Mantegna* is an excellent example of this attitude. Botero reveals the same thing as Mantegna, but from an angle that Mantegna's painting conceals. There is greater gentleness in Botero's painting, but less adherence to perspective. The subject of his painting is still living entities, the Gonzaga family, their dog, and an apple, but the way in which they appear would be called false or deformed, if judged by Renaissance criteria. Therein lies the central issue. The criteria for judging the painting must be questioned and not the painting itself.

That which is deeper than depth and which we have been referring to as sentient density uses different paths than those codified by Alberti or by the directives of Vinci. Among the explorers of these new paths, Cezanne stands out in terms of modernity. The full measure of his contribution cannot yet be taken. Contrary to the nontheoretical Impressionist aesthetic that involved painting impressions as they came to the eye, Cezanne had





30. *Woman Being Carried Off by a Demon*, 1979, 90 x 80 cm, oil on canvas.



always wanted to “bring the landscape back to the canvas,” “catch it like in a net,” “allow it to think itself.” Cezanne never abandoned his desire to *actualize* his sensations, to give them a dimension that would allow him to reunite the natural forces that participated in its engendering with the outside world in which they originated. Be it an apple, a wall, a tree trunk or a piece of board, the context of this deliberately transcendental research called for convexity, the need to model color according to mass, and to paint with the curve in mind. There’s also “something” of this theory in the forms of Botero’s *Homage to Mantegna*. The forms are not arranged in a preordained space. They aren’t modeled into a whole that integrates them and governs them from without. Instead, it appears as if each form holds within it its own center, giving the impression of many centers from which many possible spaces or levels are engendered. In *Homage to Mantegna* space is engendered by the forms. That which lies beyond their contours is neglected. Space originates from within the forms, from the forming mass that acts as it expands. As it is formed, it forms. It doesn’t form only its own contour, but the space that surrounds its contour. This is the sculptural aspect of Botero if it can be said that the sculptor in carving from fullness is also carving emptiness that gently closes around the container. Further on, we will examine how Botero explored the multiplicity of levels and the creation of a sculptural space in more detail.

At this point in our interpretation we’ll concentrate on the formation of the pictorial form

insofar as it is approached in its mass or volume and not its flatness. The form takes shape and unfolds in a brush stroke that turns in on itself, an unfolding that folds back around an absent center or around an inner part that has nothing visible or material. The more the form unfolds, the more it takes on visible consistence and curls up on itself and gains sentient density. Unlike Hundertwasser or Dubuffet in his *L’Hourloupe* series, Botero doesn’t deal with folding and unfolding for its own sake. He has a perfectly recognizable and fixed model in mind. Botero takes into account what he’s painting, even if the figuration that he produces isn’t related to the social conventions of appearance, such as we see in photography, for example. Nor does Botero start from an abstract construct, i.e., a work on canvas that’s executed according to the Renaissance convention of perspective. He doesn’t substitute the painted thing for systematic color. Botero is dealing with something much more complex, and his originality presents different challenges. His lines focus on curling back in on themselves. It’s a reflexive movement. It advances in circular form constantly coming back to the beginning, like the seasons of the year. However, the line doesn’t become a circle. It becomes a form, a thickness, a volume. From the Renaissance perspective, Botero’s forms present the effect of enlargement, an inner volume of the models that is invisible and cannot become apparent unless they downplay the trap of the mirror effect. Vinci’s words are appropriate in this respect: “When you want to see if the general effect of your canvas corresponds to the ob-

ject that is represented from nature, take a mirror and arrange it in such a way that it reflects the thing. Then compare the reflection with the painting and attentively consider whether or not the subject of the two images conforms to both. Meanwhile, study the mirror carefully. The mirror—the mirror effect—must be used as a guide, because it presents on its surface numerous points of likeness with the painting. As a matter of fact, painting is also flat and nonetheless reveals things that appear in relief. So does the mirror. The painting is a unique surface. So is the mirror.”

The trap that we’ve spoken of lies in the excess of confidence we have in the mirror effect. If painting is calibrated too much in that direction, what escapes the mirror will also escape the painting, even in the best of circumstances, including volume, or as Cezanne expressed it “the cylindrical side of objects.” “Treat nature with the cylinder, the sphere, the cone, putting all of it into perspective so that each side of an object goes towards a central point. . . .”

Cezanne tried to reconstruct this cylindrical aspect through a study of the relationship between tones from which stems an impression of thickness. Botero moves towards this, too, but without treating contrast as a dimension that is separate from the brush stroke or from the line. This is what we mean when we speak of Botero using a brush stroke that turns in on itself. The tonal differences in Botero, which separate the shapes and the forms by a mere contrast between flat tints, do not govern the totality of his research. It comes after a for-



32. *Christ*, 1976, 185 x 179 cm, oil
on canvas.

mal elaboration in which it's inscribed, a black on white structuring that is already painting. It functions like a schema or skeletal point of passage between the blindness of the canvas, which ideally is still blank, and the colored and contrasted vision that's revealed when the canvas is completed. Botero evolved this principle in Mexico during his studies of Cubism. It's a pictorial design in the sense that it always takes into account the invisible existence of volume. When Botero "structures" a canvas with drawing charcoal, he doesn't reproduce the main lines of light and shadow that a flat mirror effect or a photographic plate would reveal. On the contrary, he fixes the sketch of a form that takes into account the cylindrical effect that the mirror effect would allow to escape from the painting. One might say that Botero paints while following the advice of Vinci, except that he uses a convex mirror akin to what someone would use for a close shave. In Botero's atelier, however, both the mirror and his canvases are flat. The difference lies in the fact that the silvering found in mirrors, that opaque reverse side, which allows the "ideal aspect" of the reflection or luminosity of the image, is none other than the painter's work itself, his very body of work in the work.

The painter is not only an "eye." He's also a hand and a brain. It's a relationship between the eye and the hand guided by the head, by a thought that is aware of the limits of that which is seen. This thought offers concrete proof of this relationship, and "knows" more. To offer proof of a limit is to transcend it



33. *Watermelon*, 1976, 133 x 177 cm, oil on canvas.
34. *Oranges*, 1977, 136 x 132 cm, oil on canvas.



35. *Watermelon*, 1968.

without physically going beyond it. This is what metaphysics is, what an idea is. In painting, ideas are always exclusively visible. They are never abstract, never transparent like concepts are. Botero stated: "It's my ideas that transform the reality of my subject."* A pictorial idea is always pictorial. Each person can see that there's a swelling effect, a willful, figurative, monumental character attributed to everything, be it something small or naturally large to begin with. What is true for *The President* or for *Christ* is also true for *Oranges* or for *Watermelon*. Everybody can see this effect, but, it's more difficult to decipher what it means. It might be said that Botero integrates the convexity of things into the flat surface of the canvas, that he unifies the *solidity* of what is figurative in that which he reveals. This integration of what is pictorially nonexistent—volume—to the existing canvas presented Botero with an infinite number of problems with regard to presentation. *Madame Cezanne in the Garden* is highly indicative of this. The roundness of the face and the power of colored contrasts are like a homage rendered to Cezanne's theories, and yet the utter simplicity of the painting is also a refutation of Cezanne. Botero seems to be saying "it's possible to reveal things in a better and more forceful way."

Not only paintings that portray a scream can scream (in this instance we think of Munch, Bacon, or the Belgian Vandyke. . .). A still life can also scream. In a Botero still life there's the black that indicates the inside of the half-open door on the table that supports the still life. Botero's black is luminous and pene-

trating, as if the sun were shining on it, and renders the cutting edge of the occult to simplest of comestibles as well as the table that supports them. The mystery, weight, and silence of things, their underlying solidity, their *absoluteness*, come right onto center stage with the thundering roar of silence. With this *black*, the inside of things is turned right side out. When this happens, it's not blinding like the sun's rays that ricochet over a white stone or are reflected in a mirror. To the contrary, this black unleashes a gently enveloping serenity. It's too powerful for vehemence. It works, as Nietzsche would say, "like that which is good, on the wings of the dove." Instead of negating the existence of that which is completely revealed and apparent, Botero's black reinforces the fullness of that which it surrounds. It acts in the same way that "difference" acts. It separates and makes distinctions, but it also rejoins and conjoins. True difference does not permit its extremes to exist separately. True difference unites, is situated *between* things, in the middle of things. Likewise for the black on the canvas. Difference also returns behind the things and supports them in their coexistence. Like the black on the canvas, black is not only the separation from the center. It's also the ring or circle that turns on itself and keeps the things that it encircles turning towards their center. Difference is a circular line that distinguishes one thing from another thing, but encircles them, as well, in the simplicity and fullness of their being.

Painted years apart, both *Madame Cezanne in the Garden* and the later still lifes "refute" Cezanne while praising him.



36. *The Pinzon Family*, 1965, 173 x 173 cm, oil on canvas.

* Arcinegas, G., *Botero*, p. 51.



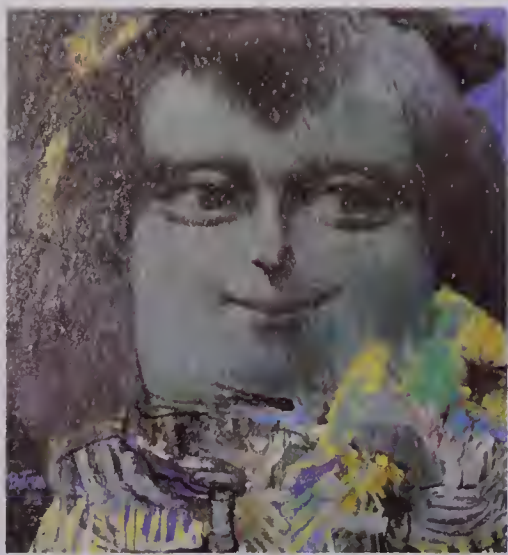
To be sure, there is no reference to Cezanne in the still lifes, but the use of black, which supports and differentiates all other colors, was definitely on Cezanne's palette. True light, or true brilliance cannot exist without a relationship to darkness. Day does not exist without night. His being at the heart of this truth endowed Botero's work with self-confidence and strength. With regard to Botero, the man, he was constantly finding himself and losing himself in his work. Botero, a nomad in life, lived in Colombia, Dublin, New York, Paris, and Italy. Likewise, he never ceased being in exile at the heart of his work, which wouldn't allow him to turn into his nonpictorial "self." It's impossible to find the man on the cover of *Vogue* or through the personal events in his life. He exists entirely in his painting, in his work. In a profound way, his painting creates him only to eject him from the natural world where all things live and die without a beyond, and without the transcendence of art.

Difference that differentiates, which separates and postpones, is also the simplicity of the return of a presence. Otherwise stated, it's the creation of fullness, the most difficult of all. Several years before he painted *Madame Cezanne in the Garden*, and shortly after *Homage to Mantegna*, Botero was in the groove of what we have tried to render (the search for a figurative solidity by bring to light that which supports the faces of people, that which allows them not only to have a face, but to exist). He was painting portraits of every young girl, trying to liberate the fullness of form and not the fullness of their figures or their flesh. Midway

37. *Little Girl*, 1962, 180 x 163 cm, oil on canvas.



38. *Frontal View of a Woman*,
1978, 160 x 185 cm, oil on
canvas.



between Rubens and Bellmer, he studied the ways of making visible that which envelops appearance without sacrificing appearance. A woman who was sweeping the floor in Botero's studio exclaimed: "It's like the Mona Lisa." Thus the title: *Mona Lisa, Age Twelve*. Again, we're faced with an indirect and ambiguous homage, despite its seeming simplicity and frankness. Except for the famous smile that cuts through the flesh and allows life to be seen in those famous dimples, where it is suspended and held back, Botero's painting and its subject are revealed in an entirely different way. The enormity of the face, with its enigmatic irony and its fragile ampleness, is completely condensed in the head, which contrasts with the smallness of the arms and hands. None of this disproportion is found in Vinci, who invented and theorized the mirroring of appearance. Botero didn't negate appearance. Nor did he take it through the ringer in the thoughtful manner of Magritte or in the violent manner of Dado. He was trying to reveal the contents of what appearance conceals to normal sight to allow it to come up through the luminescence of appearance. Nothing was more abstract than a photograph. Nothing was less photographic than this "Mona Lisa," younger than the real one, and still not at all the reflection of a phenomenon, but instead the genetic reflection of the visible reflection. Botero sought through form the contents that made the form possible. He integrated the genesis and anteriority of form into the form. There was no origin of form because there was no initial white. Instead, we can



39. *Mona Lisa, Age Twelve*, 1979, 211 x 195 cm, oil on canvas.

40. *Mona Lisa*, 1978, 187 x 166 cm, oil on canvas.





41. *Girl on a Donkey*, 1959, 174 x 77 cm, oil on canvas.

speak of a youth of form, that which form was before representation, before the triumph of phenomenology. Botero wielded a savvy naïveté comparable to the Primitives who painted small and large things with equal importance, each thing according to its own essence. *Girl on a Donkey*, dating from this same period, demonstrates this. This concern predates Botero's concern for perspective. The body of the donkey is smaller than the dress that envelops the body of the young girl, which itself is smaller than the girl's head. The head is surrounded and overwhelmed with hair and a hat that are also completely disproportionate. Disproportion is one of the techniques Botero used to widen the gap between things and the appearance of things. Difference was buried there, and revealed itself as that which was incapable of being revealed.

Disproportion, which is not deformity, was used by Botero with great mastery. *Man Leaving for the Office* is a striking example of this. Let's bet that once this somewhat austere man gets to his office, he'll be in a universe in scale with his own. Is this house, which is too big for him and already too small for those who live there, his home? . . . There are numerous Botero paintings that use this technique. Take for example the cat and the character in the foreground of *Family Scene*, dated 1969, or Jesus and his mother in *Our Lady of Colombia*. There's also the dog in another *Family Scene*, dated 1967, and the disproportion between *The Lovers*. Again, Botero used disproportion as one of the paths of difference. For Botero, difference brings things together. It doesn't separate



42. *Aurora*, 1972, 159 x 122 cm, pastel.



things. It envelops things as opposed to cutting through them; it goes from the center and reemerges from behind to render beauty and mystery to the subjects. Something visible that conceals within it that from which it comes has beauty. To obtain this beauty it's not enough to wrap these things in clothes or fabrics and transform them, as Christo does for publicity purposes, or as Man Ray did with a Dadaist wink of the eye. For beauty to be revealed, it must not be hidden. It must penetrate throughout (*under* and *in*) its concealment or its appearance (these two words are interchangeable).

Contrast within a single subject, the head and the hands of *Madame Rubens* (1963), for example, or contrast between subjects, as the pairs of shoes in *Portrait of Mr. and Mrs. Messer* (1968), functions as an appropriation in form of that which is formless. Form cannot be adjusted to or proportionate to that which is concealed. For this reason the appropriation of concealment is always expressed as a disproportion, what Heidegger called "an event." Through this "event," Heidegger reinstates to the notion of *Ereignis* that which designates what is essential in and of itself. At the same time, the nonessential, cursory glance allows this to take place. The visualization or appearance on the canvas is accompanied by a distortion that must not only be there, but be seen, be visible, as well. It's disproportion that often accomplishes this task in the paintings of Botero.

Disproportion must not be thought of as a relationship between the forms that are already there, but rather as a relationship of form to that

43. *Madame Rubens*, 1968, 229 x 186 cm, oil on canvas.



44. *Man Leaving for the Office*,
1969, 185 x 185 cm, oil on
canvas.



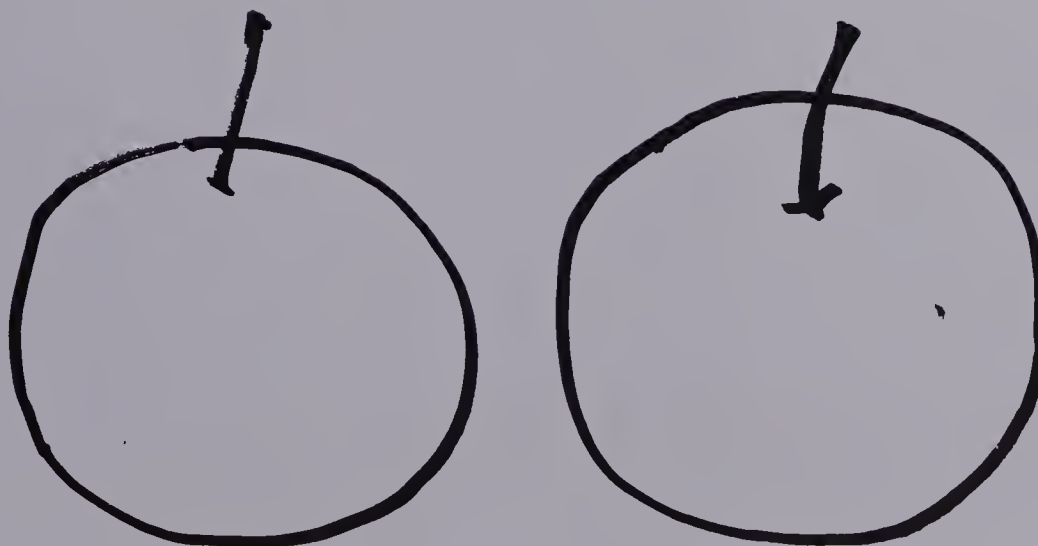
45. *Protestant Family*, 1969, 209
x 175 cm, oil on canvas.

which is formless, but which form nonetheless manages to appropriate despite its formless nature. Disproportion is part of the very nature of Botero's paintings. Botero's flat space integrates the convexity of that which is sentient or the convexity of what is sentient becomes level without becoming flat. It becomes smoother not only while sustaining contrast but while accentuating it. This is the "scream" we referred to with regard to some of the still lifes. It's also the dimension that renders *Mona Lisa, Age Twelve* a sincere and forthright homage to Leonardo da Vinci.

The spirit of painting is similar to that of philosophy as described by Hegel: the expectation of works of the mind that share an affinity and that above all are different. Henceforth, the difference of Vinci is the best of tributes to Vinci on the part of Botero, although Botero didn't limit himself to this. Botero played less with disproportion in his later paintings. He used it instead as a means of rounding out form. Botero's use of excess roundness is roundness that shows that it's never round enough, never enveloping enough to allow that which it must contain to become visible, even when it's a matter of making it come forth!

Form in Botero's painting is a line that turns back on itself and is more intensive than extensive. Botero demonstrated this from the outset. His sketches underlie the difference between a cutout or an arabesque of Matisse and his own way of conferring intense formality on form. This same dimension can be captured in *Sunflowers*, Botero's dialogue with Van Gogh (the most intense of painters), who confided to his brother Theo:

"Once again I got carried away and painted stars that were too big." In contrast to the violence of Van Gogh's sunflowers, Botero offers the power of serenity. It's from within that Botero's sunflowers are strong and bring forth their sunflower essence. Within his sunflowers, we find the darkness that makes light dance on it. Botero's sunflowers have not been captured from the luminous dance of outside light. The dance is the outcome of their inner strength, their density.



46. *Sketch of Apples*, 1985.



47. *The Thief*, 1980, 165 x 192 cm,
oil on canvas.

Wherever Botero's eye happened to settle was the start of what we call "Boteroism." He gradually drew and painted a way of seeing the world that was rooted in a technique of painting. If this did not govern all his work, it most certainly guided it. To forge a way of seeing the world is to have a creative idea. It's to establish a way of forming this idea through which formlessness (the pure meaning of sentence) can be captured in a form that is suited to it. This form contains that which preexisting forms have failed to capture. The only way to view a painting is to see in it that which others have not revealed. To see something in the same way is as easy as it is useless—a small amount of erudition is all it requires. However, to see that which is different, and which the work brings into being each time that it's viewed, demands looking at something in another way. It demands a "cultivated" eye or, as Kant expressed it, an "adhering" eye.

The philosopher Koenigsberg emphasized that the stereotypical aspect of the "adhering eye" cannot really teach or instruct, given the fact that it comes equipped with its own criteria and merely applies it to or imposes it on the work. It evolves according to a preexisting scale of values and is regulated by preexisting norms. This book deals with a different kind of "eye," the kind that Kant qualifies as "reflective." There's no comparison between this eye and Hegel's conscious eye of experience, or Heidegger's experience of thought. The reflective eye determines its own criteria in what it sees instead of putting

what it sees within preexisting frames of reference. To trace the creative act of Botero, it's necessary to follow the creative principle that animates it. This principle is constantly renewed and modified as it returns to its beginnings. When Botero focused on the form of a mandolin, he made the hole in the center of the instrument disproportionately large. A hundred and one problems emerged from this, all of which originated in the idea of figurative monumentality, each of which involved how to apply and render this idea in a more precise way.

The progressive or repetitive revelations of a figurative idea constantly take us back to the origin of the idea in order to render a *different* version of it. Thus, the creative person creates himself through his creation, which in turn creates an origin for itself. Otherwise expressed: The creative artist constantly anticipates his own past and gives a retrospective of the future. His existence presents itself as a debt that he has incurred and that can be paid off only through the creative act.

From the very outset Botero was on this path. From the mandolin he went on to fruits. First came the apple, a biblical symbol of human imperfection. This was followed by his portraits and landscapes. Each was governed by the emergence of sentience that is inherent in form. The flat image deprives form of sentient density. However, it wasn't enough to render excessive richness or sentient density to form in order to accomplish the best result in the painted work. From the moment many

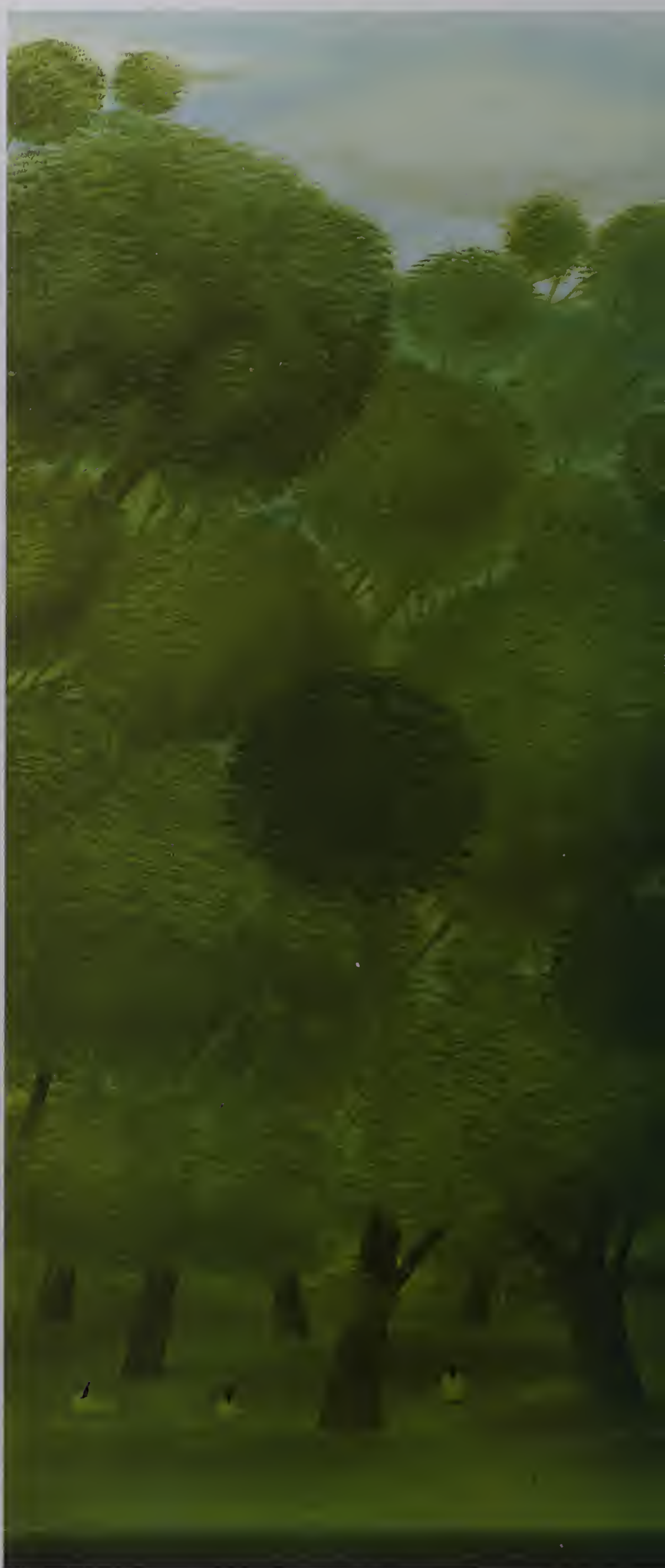
forms undergo this process, the question of their coexistence within the immanent space of the canvas is raised.

III the interplay of levels: immanence and transcendence

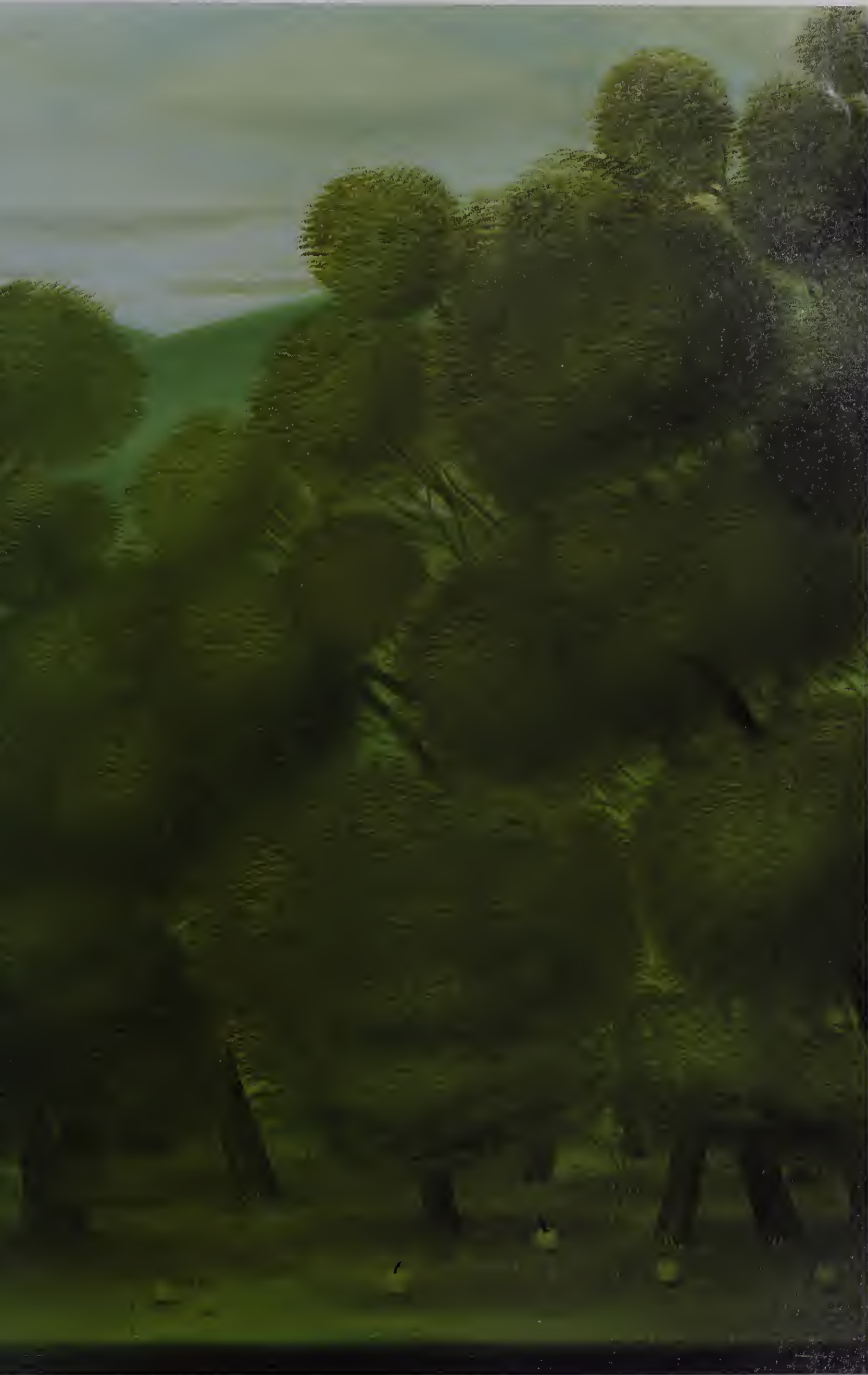
The Musicians is an example of what we've referred to as the pictorial integration of convexity that becomes leveled without becoming flat. We can speak of two confronting surfaces in the works of Botero, one abstract and the other real. The most obvious one in Botero's work is abstract or transcendent aspect. The "reality" aspect draws it to what is outside the work insofar as it avoids the concept of realism. What is real lies in the relationship through which the sentient visibility of the world affects the sensibilities of the artist.

To bring the painting back towards this sentient foundation is tantamount to viewing it as a reproduction of an invisible model that exists outside the painting itself. Henceforth, this transcendental reproduction, which is the actual production of the painted work, takes on a role of primary importance. In other words, the canvas is producing a reality right in front of our eyes that wasn't already there in the form that the canvas reveals it.

It's only *after* the pictorial work that the forms start to imitate the canvas and to be seen in another way. If a small man with a large guitar, or vice versa, immediately makes you see something else, if it captures in some way that which is invisible, it's because Botero possessed the art of giving form to what is disproportionate. He made this a rigorous principle, not just a marginal procedure. By liberating a sentient thrust that distends form from within and magnifies it without eliminating it, Botero adhered to what the schema of ordinary sight censors or inevitably dissimulates. This is what we have referred to as the tran-



48. *Landscape*, 1979, 167 x 192 cm, oil on canvas.





49. *Self-Portrait*, 1970, 109 x 94 cm, oil on canvas.



50. *Madonna*, 1977, 226 x 183 cm, oil on canvas.

scendental dimension of his work. It's the dimension through which the canvas communicates with what is beyond it, and in so doing connects with that which usually escapes what we see. Nonetheless, when Botero continually stated that he painted the houses, green landscapes, fruits, cats, bishops, flowers, women, and soldiers of his native Colombia, this coexisted pictorially with the immanent place on which the painting was revealed, that space where neither depth nor organic life existed—the canvas. Our earlier study of disproportion touched on this problem with regard to the role of mirrors. Botero's invention of sentient forms, forms which are clearly adjoined to volume, does not correspond to the classic notion of pictorial space.

The likeness between mirrors and canvases is far from perfect. Only one common element exists between them. This element is as problematic as it is enlightening. It's enlightening if we refer to the text that we've quoted from Vinci: Canvas and mirror are spaces without depth, spaces in which the difference between interiority and exteriority can be summed up as recto-verso.

However, while the mirror only functions with regard to its silvering, the canvas functions through the action of the painter's body, which gives it life and is able to go beyond the mechanically reproductive virtues of the mirrored image. This is the crux of what is problematic: The level of transcendence is superimposed over the level of immanence. Because the mirror is loyal to what is reflected, it is less versatile than painting, which is essentially unfaithful. The

transcendental aspect of the work of art creates the impression of something beyond the painting itself that starts with the canvas itself.

This creative process, however, demands the use of totally artificial means that have nothing organic about them. Botero admitted: "Before each and every painting I do, I think about the means with which I paint, the why and where-withal of the brushes and the hairs on the brushes, the function of the canvas in front of me, my erect posture . . . I think about everything that leads to the work and is subjugated to it." The level of immanence, according to this statement, is not easily reduced to middle ground. It's more a matter of a *sine qua non* situation. In the French language, the words *canvas* (*toile*) and *work* (*oeuvre*) are not arbitrarily used almost interchangeably. This happens because "in" and "on" the immanence of the canvas is where the idea that transcends the canvas is engendered. The form that gives body to the invisible is grafted onto it. This level is not transcendental and ideal in itself, and it only becomes so when worked upon. Its reality in itself is superficial and abstract. It is separate from being, and cut off from that which exists. Through this blinding difference, however, it must be reconstituted into that from which it was cut off. This demands a "new form," one that is different and takes into account both the separation and the condition of its transcendence. It's not a matter of representation in painting. It's a matter of "presentation," of moving towards things without giving them flesh or blood.

It's this inorganic necessity

that, due to abstraction and to the artificial nature of the act of painting, allows the person taking communion in *Self-portrait: The Day of My First Communion* to coexist with devils. Another example is the presentation of two right feet and two right hands in *Male Study*. Opposites could not exist and painting could not unfold as an act of contradiction without the real and the abstract immanence of the canvas. "Boteroism," which focuses on the fullness of forms, works like all painting in its reliance on an immanent space, which in itself seems not only to contradict pictorial focus but to nip it in the bud.

It's true that the process of perspective—smallness for distance, largeness for closeness, and the rule that "every object hides another object"—creates an illusion of depth and a semblance of volume. Despite this effect, the process is incomplete, because simulated volume is neutral. It doesn't coexist well with the intense volume of form in Botero's work. Moreover, it's not enough just to multiply the painting's centers of intensity. This only causes the painting to lose its unity, since it affects various parts of the canvas in different ways. Botero was not able to accentuate the round presence of a face or a bust without having to accentuate the roundness of the whole, and without inventing a mode of composition that bends the flat space to this intensity. Likewise, through an inverse movement, he had to bend the intensity of the form to the laws of flatness.

This latter aspect of movement has not been frequently spoken of in studies devoted to Botero. Nonetheless, it is very obvious and is the object of study in numerous can-



vases. *Vermeer's Studio*, painted in 1964, is one example. The distribution of space seems to occur on successive levels. A window within the painting is arranged as a frame within a frame. Up against this window are Botero's version of a famous Vermeer face and apples. Further into the painting, at the center of the place on which the "window" seems to open, is a representation of the same Vermeer face. This Vermeer face is not in the manner of Botero, at least in terms of what is supposed to concern the unreality of the image inscribed on the surface of the background, because the background is itself unreal. The window frame and the easel have the solidity and the volume that are characteristic of Botero's universe. There's a darker background that closes the successive plans and refers the work of Vermeer and Botero's interpretation of it from one level to the next. This painting is presented as a reflection. It's a meditation on painting, on the quasi alchemical elaboration during the course of which immanence mixes with transcendence.

Based on this almost Magrittean reflection on pictorial space, *Vermeer's Studio* illustrates how far Botero was from ontological realism and from representational illusion. Thanks to a use of perspective that triggers two levels and relates them to each other, as in an ideal dialogue, Botero simultaneously penetrates and eliminates the difference between what is real and what is unreal. In doing so, Botero reveals a difference that resides at the heart of this relationship, a difference that conceals the essence of painting. After *Vermeer's Studio*, pictorial art



52. *Still Life*, 1982, 133 x 146 cm, oil on canvas.
53. *Vermeer's Studio*, 1964, 106 x 104 cm, oil on canvas and collage.



produces a “beyond” or a “thereness” that remains rooted in the “hereness” of a background support, which is the canvas itself. Transcendence is present, given the fact that in this work Botero is having a dialogue with the reality of Vermeer and with Vermeer himself. Nonetheless, this transcendence functions from an immanence at the heart of which two intermittently immanent and transcendent levels converse. These levels oppose each other as the immanence or the transcendence of the other. Consider the work of Vermeer like the transcendent horizon on which Botero’s composition is accomplished. The work henceforth becomes a type of homage, but this point of view can and must be inverted. In this instance it’s Vermeer who seems to be the mean that Botero uses to incarnate his own vision. This reciprocity between immanence and transcendence, or this back and forth from Botero to Vermeer and from Vermeer to Botero, offers a combination of levels, the use of which owes nothing to Vermeer. As with all Botero’s versions of past works of art, it’s important to retain the following difference: On the left side of Vermeer’s paintings we almost always find a window that filters in light from the outside. In the background there is a wall that is most often decorated with a painting, a map, or a mirror that refers to the scene in the foreground, where an object, be it a table or a rug, keeps the viewer at a distance.

Vermeer encircled and protected the intimacy he revealed. Take *The Music Lesson*, for instance. He had an incomparable way of surprising and suspending empti-

54. *Cardinal*, 1979, 165 x 193 cm, oil on canvas.

55. *Man on Horseback*, 1984, 180 x 126 cm, oil on canvas.



56. *The Street*, 1980, 193 x 161
cm, oil on canvas.



ness, a way of allowing “nothingness” to function while prohibiting us from disturbing it. Vermeer arrived at truth through detail and the extreme rigor of his composition. He painted only what rendered painting possible and seemed to neglect everything that couldn’t be seen. He captured nothingness in a magical equilibrium, in a movement of light that was infinitely precise, yet not at all ponderous. The drawings of Vermeer enclose an absence that is not embodied. They miraculously allow that which they enclose to remain disembodied.

Botero, to the contrary, always gave body to what must be seen. He never allowed volume to dissolve in a play of color. If we were to use the language of Heidegger, we could say that where Vermeer seemed to focus on “being” as “being,” Botero focused on the metaphysics of “being” in the Aristotelian sense, “being” as “being something,” “being” as sentient. When he had encircled emptiness, he almost always turned it into an affirmative power, such as the horseman, and above all the horse on a deserted road, or the poor, frozen burglar in the middle of a maze of rooftops. For this reason from Vermeer to Botero the relationship between immanence and transcendence, between the abstract surface and the concealed surface that acquires depth, the relationship between Vermeer and Botero has neither the same meaning nor the same goal. Vermeerian transcendence is enclosed within the interiority of the painting, within the immanence of the drawing. It focuses on something incorporeal, something invisible that remains insentient. Botero fo-

cused on the sentience of that which is invisible. He finished the space of his canvas only in relationship to the result obtained, the point at which something erupted in the course of his creative experience. Otherwise stated, Botero’s “framing” followed the opening to sentience that was organized by additions that moved the surface towards the background.

This same aspect explodes in a superb painting that the artist had in New York. It was a huge, white-washed wall on which the immanence of the canvas gives surprising life to different zones of agitation at the bottom and to the right. The composition was like an abstract study (a rectangle and an inverted “L,” such as what one finds in the paintings of Kupka). Instead of contrasting black against white in the immanence of color, Botero contrasted street life, rooftops, and landscapes against the blinding whiteness. The lime-washed Colombian house animates everything around it that it is not. This element gives life to that which is not it. This is the role of drawing in Botero’s work. It stays the same, but refers to what came before. It gives play to “otherness.”

The role of framing is to capture and fix this double, triple, or quadruple referencing. It’s a captivating study of angles of vision. This study achieves its apex in *Corridas* in which Botero created an original way of working. He didn’t paint on a canvas that was pre-mounted on a stretcher. Instead, he used a pulley device and hidden adhesives. He was looking for his framing after the fact. It was done from what was already painted and not in terms of what still had to be painted. It started after the

57. *Girl on the Balcony*, 1983, 122 x 89 cm, oil on canvas.



58. *Bishop*, 1982, 235 x 135 cm,
oil on canvas.



59. *My Room*, 1978, 193 x 144 cm,
oil on canvas.

conquered canvas was already saturated. This overabundance opened up onto an already captured exterior.

It's the play of this lively movement that constitutes the motif of *My Room*, dated 1978: The artist sleeping, the mountains, the mirror, the painting, the apple, and the painter's tools are immobilized in a dance around the canvas that is still blank, but already expecting that which will come to animate and sustain it. Also, in the manner of *The Room*, dated 1982, the real subject of the painting is not in the room, which is merely symbolic. It's the same for the occupant of this room whom we don't see. We don't know whether he's sleeping or outside going for a swim. The clothes heaped on the table, however, signal the concealed existence of the man whom they belong to. The painting is the juncture between the world it effectively captures and that which in the background is absent and sustains the world that is concealed. As Heidegger saw it, "the shoes" are the very symbol of the way in which a work of art functions: the revelation of *difference* between the world that painting forms and the earth that in this world remains concealed. The pictorial world is a world that refers back to itself: The shoes of Van Gogh refer to the pilgrim that he was. The shoes of Arnolfini refer to the union that they contracted under the eye of Van Eyck. The shoes in Botero's *The Room* subtly unveil the existence of the person who wears them. This restoration of the motif or "object" to the work of art is always accompanied by that which cannot be restored: infinity.

Botero's tables refer to everything that they support. The



60. *The Room*, 1982, 176 x 111 cm, oil on canvas.



shoes that the owners of the shoes should be made to wear are in and of themselves an infinite reference. The levels in Botero's paintings never allow the transcendent circulation between these levels to be organized, be it the goal of magnificence in form or, to a more limited end, the use of white as an element in the work that allows it to refer to itself as "other" than itself.

The Botero Exhibit, dated 1975, was an extraordinary example of these references from level to level that Botero was so fond of. Without ever extending beyond the surface of the canvas, these levels are like a path through which the work travels back to itself and uses itself for its own model. There are paintings in which Botero seems to want to reduce his work to an element of itself, as if he intended to include the whole of it in a sub-whole. *The Botero Exhibit* integrates the walls on which the paintings are shown and the characters who move about in front of them. An infinite coming and going between the works of art and the painted spectators is opened up, as if this were happening between two parallel mirrors. The eye of the spectator is our eye, and it suddenly embraces the entire painting. In turn, we are led to move from one point of viewing to another, just as we are at an art exhibit.

The Botero Exhibit is, of course, simulated. Nonetheless, this simulation takes a poke at real exhibitions and openings during which men and women look more at one another than they do at the paintings, which is supposed to be their reason for being there. The painting makes us think about what an exhibition is, how it should be experienced, and how it should



62. *The Bathroom*, 1983, 180 x 120 cm, oil on canvas.



63. *The Collector of Boteros*,
1984, 136 x 163 cm, oil on
canvas.



work. In this way the painting works on us like a lesson in painting or in "Boteroism." It can also be said that it acts like a lesson in life and in behavior.

It's always a question of painting or art with Boterism, but it's never limited to this. The effects of art on life are a major element in the painter's work. By capturing the abstract immanence of the canvas, Botero refers the spectator to a reality that is transformed and seen in a totally different way. In this sense Botero's work is eminently active. His descriptions escape being that which they describe, or, more appropriately, that which they bring into being or intervene in. Botero's eye, as in his bullfights, for example, are essentially interior. He looks at things from within the spectacle. The eye of the bull crosses the eye of the matador, and the eye of the painter sees a wholeness from which exteriority seems to be excluded. Botero differs in this sense from Goya, and, more recently, from Pomar or Bacon. That which fixes the works of Botero doesn't come from the spectator's contemplation, which fixes movement. On the contrary, it appears to emanate from struggle, it surges up from within a duel or struggle in which the bulls and the matadors form a whole. This whole is at the same time explosive and cruel. It is mythical. There is noise and silence, blood and sunshine, dark forces and mortal dexterity. The matador, like the painter, marks matter with his style and gives it form, and in so doing he repels or domesticates the blind forces from the world of sentience. Like the painter, he must put the forces unchained against him to death. His most



64. *Saint Rose of Lima*, 1968, 175 x 168 cm, oil on canvas.canvas.



65. *Siesta*, 1982.
135 x 172 cm,
oil on canvas.







67. *Tree*, 1978, 118 x 192 cm, oil on canvas.



masterful art is to conquer these forces when they come as close as they can get, when these forces are at their maximum power and at their most dangerous.

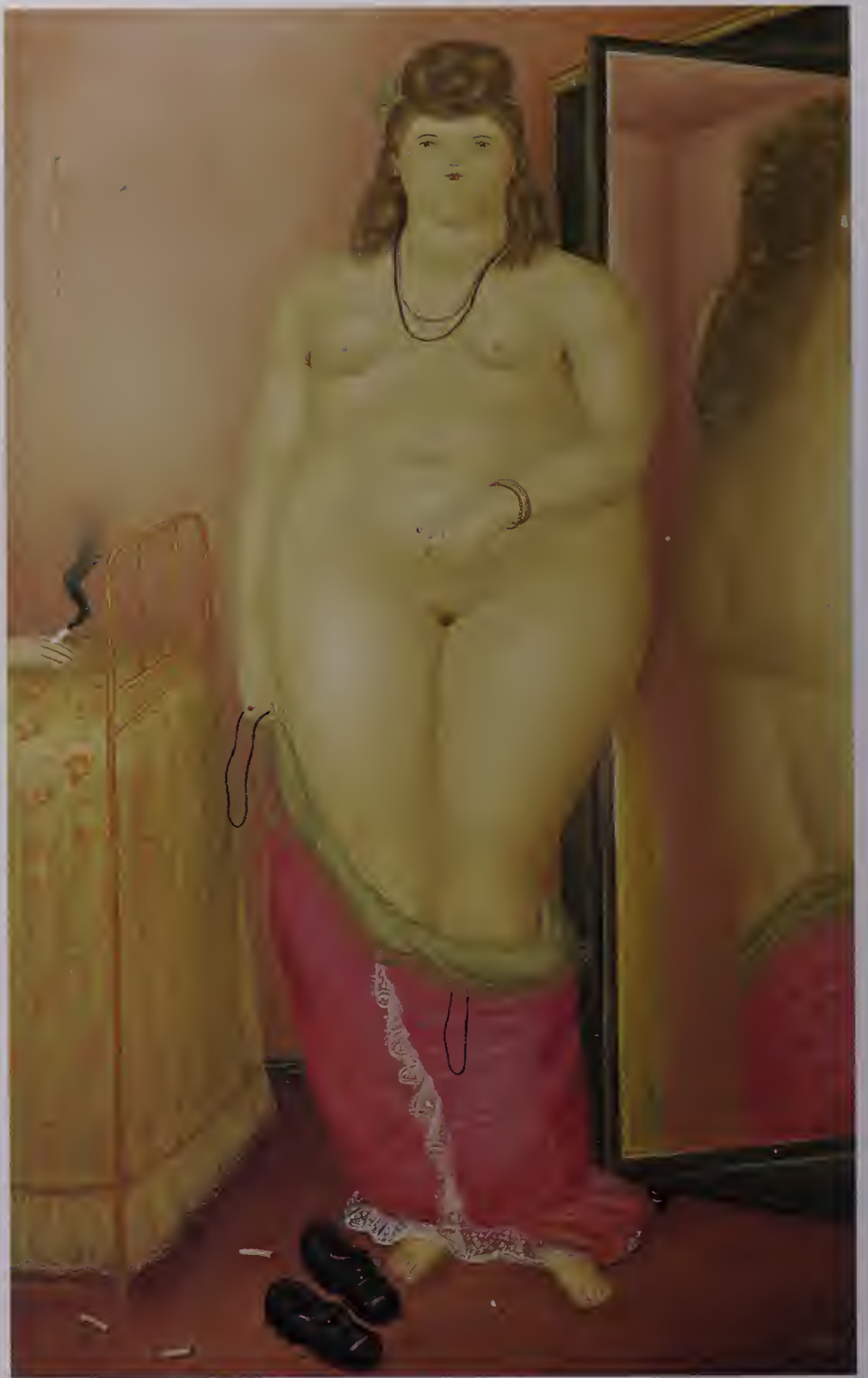
As a child, Botero thought of becoming a matador. His painting is never neutral or abstract. Nor does it have a self-sufficient language or system of self-reference. His painting always shows something and is addressed to itself at the center of itself. It always makes a first detour through the "model" in a two-fold sense of the word: It takes a model from otherness, but fashions this otherness according to its own will. It's the vision of the spectator that it is modeling and guiding towards emotion. It does this by leading it back to where the schema that structure ordinary vision prevent it from going—into the very flesh of sentience, into the "inner density" of things. It's quite extraordinary that Botero's bullfights are never reduced to mere spectacle, but instead to their very being, their sentient dimension. He integrates everything that ordinarily isn't seen and that relates only to the bullfight into his vision of the world.

Botero's work is too knowledgeable to be caught in the trap of representational ideology. It never opts for a figuration that would resign itself to abstraction or to what we refer to since Paul Klee as teleological immanence.

Botero was well aware that the multiplicity of levels originated in the immanence of the one level. The meaning that must be attributed to their interplay is at the crux of the matter, and demands interpretation. Take the example of a woman's head that emerges in the foreground of a still life



69. *Ride Along a Lake*, 1984.



in *The Botero Collector*. It makes our way of seeing more complex and acts as an additional obstacle with a double function: to reenforce our feeling of distance with regard to the subject of the work of art, and in the same instance to draw us closer by eliciting a reflex reaction to the work. It obliges us to make a mental detour, and reminds us that we are dealing with a painting. Botero did this much in the same way that Godard drew our attention to the cinema when he constantly reminded us that it was cinema. When he needed to drive his point home, Godard even revealed the camera in front of a camera. Botero's head, this small head that is outside the frame and inside the frame, draws attention to the difference between life and art within the work, the fact that it's part of the anatomy of the canvas but also on the outskirts, somewhat like a signature.

In *Ride Along a Lake*, a horseman rides near a woods. In the foreground there's a pond. The trees are enormous. Looking directly at them one can barely see more than their trunks. The horse hardly reaches beyond the height of the trunks, but the water of the supposed lake reflects them in their entirety. They almost reach the mountaintops and the sky . . . Reflection in a reflection, the painting is divided into two unequal parts. One part is based on the most obvious representational illusion that is the most apparently naïve. The other and more important undermines this naïveté by using an astonishingly subtle trick. The painting is a reflection on an optical reflection, a half-inverted meditation. The optical reflection does not liberate

itself from realist illusion. It uses an optical pretext, signals that which is reflected, an assumed lake. This painting is startling in the lucidity of its humor and simplicity of its self-denied savvy. It clearly affirms the opposite of what it reveals. It affirms painting as painting, and affirms its supreme independence, its absolute heterogeneity.

It also reveals his "dependence" on the primacy of what is visible. Things are primary, but they appear only in a secondary way. In response to their sentient density there's the reflection of the reflection on art that refers us to something beyond phenomena. One could say that without referring to Aristotle, the painting espouses Aristotle's sublime advice to the letter: "Impossible but true-to-life things are better than possible things that are not true to life!" Botero was highly aware of what painting could and, therefore, couldn't do. He seemed to want to limit the ability of his art, in order to better push it closer to its limit. He endlessly made that which was secondary into a primary element of the painting. In these inversions the smallness of a hand could say more than an enormous face. These plays of disproportion, which are appropriated to the discretion of that which is seen under the eye of the visionary, bring us back to the primary emotion, to the visual affectivity that art allows to be restricted and that can only be captured at the center of an assumption that discontinuity governs. The final framing, the final brush stroke, fixes the pictorial enclosure (the teleological closure) in an open system. There are innumerable oblique mirrors in Botero's work that are badly hung, and



that refer to the central theme of the painting in only marginal fashion. It's as if they have a life of their own, or had their problems of reflection somewhere else. These mirrors are endowed with their own level of activity and are like supplementary perspectives enclosed within the canvas. They are a concrete reflection on the fact that painting sees things from within, that its intrinsic dynamism and potential power are in no way coming from abstraction or an extrinsic source.

If it's true that the human sense of sight has taken precedence over the other senses, and if it's true that metaphysics issues from the culture of this excess, then it can be said of Greek culture that a being was not invented, but seen, *revealed*. It must also be emphasized that this kind of power contains uncertainty and anguish, as well as everything dangerous and precarious in such an escape into ecstasy. It's the flight of the body far beyond as well as far into its inner depths. Painting isn't only the fixing of appearances against the infinite mobility of phenomena. It's also a matter of bringing closer and holding that which is far away and evasive. Botero was a master of capturing this. Painting for him went hand in hand with joining that which was farthest away with that which was most intimate, close, secret and silent.

There is something essential in the muteness of painting, in the reciprocally obstinate alliance of the eye and the hand that wholly unites against or with the power of words. Most often, except in philosophy, words refer to words without too much attention to the things that the words are sup-

71. *Woman Undressing*, 1984, 191 x 127 cm, oil on canvas.



72. *Colombian Woman*, 1979, 182
x 130 cm, oil on canvas.



posed to signify. In this particular sense, painting is far from all chatter. It takes refuge within the mysterious silence of things and is thus a lesson for philosophy. Painting is at home in contradiction. It is comfortable there, completely in its element. It perpetually balances contradictory forces, allying manual proximity with the farsightedness of vision. In its solitary alchemy, it captures that which resists conceptualization in images. This is the very nature of painting's being. For this reason, painting is a mannerism for eyes fatigued by science and consciousness. Painting unifies the rage to encompass everything to the apprehending will and work of the hand.

Painting is never *essential* in the phenomenological sense of the word; rather it is nourished by that part of flesh that escapes the spoken word. It's impossible to "talk" a good painting. Painting resists this. It offers figurative solidity to the eye, but it slips away with words. The lavishness of painting conceals. It makes us go from critical jargon to disarming silence. There is no just balance possible between these two. Immanence and transcendence refer back and forth to each other in a kind of dissonance, contrast, or tonal disharmony. Immanence and transcendence fuse in something that escapes canon. There's a will to remain unclassifiable in painting, a systematic will to remain marginal. For this reason, Botero's clear and willful singularity, his deliberately paradoxical dimension, brings him the closest possible to that which is essential. Some of his themes may appear anachronistic or displaced, and it might seem foolish to cross trees in the same way

that Ucello crossed swords, or to attribute figurative monumentality to watermelons and musicians at a country fair, but this is exactly what is willfully singular. It is the blatantly abnormal that must capture our attention. Botero was able to uncork the "marvelous" and cultivate aberration and disproportion by being simultaneously central and marginal. Without the way he had of sliding back and forth between fixing transcendence and moving immanence, art would not be Art.

Botero's work is in the grand tradition of style, the kind that erupts when it's least expected. Against all probability it imposes itself without concern to intellectual resistance or the petty conventions of "good taste." Great Art, like wisdom, is akin to madness. It takes its distance from common sense and sacred stereotypes. It folds in on itself, on its "otherworldliness," and from this place it returns into the cavern of clichés and fashion to bend everything it encounters to its supreme singularity. Henceforth, this singularity is imposed as being better than the norm that it separated from or that was separated from it.

In the aftermath of the work, that which is normal submits, acknowledging the remains of what exceeds it. Normality admits this "super-sistance," without which all that is human could not stand straight, experience anxiety, or, from time to time, experience the happiness of being able to form in a human image that which affects us and our lives.



74. *Family Portrait*, 1983, 135 x 160 cm, oil on canvas.



75. *First Lady*, 1967, 190 x 168
cm, oil on canvas.

We have referred to the works of Botero as characterized on the one hand by figurative solidity (the willful rendering of "sentient density" in the rhythm and form of what is visible) and on the other hand by levels of self-reference and reference to other things. The effect of transcendence, simply stated, is beauty. Beauty results from the combination or the conjunction of these two dimensions of figurative solidity and a system of references. The levels exist in terms of capturing what is sentient and are a willful effort to bring sentience to the highest degree of visible intensity. The ineffable aspect of this intensity is what the spectator is in communication with and what allows him to experience transcendence.

We've noted often that the pictorial language of Botero, although abstract in the sense that all painting is first abstract, is not a language that's invented at every stage. It's a language that has been elaborated through a study of tradition that included Botero's study of fresco in Florence,* as well as his contact with Ucello, Velasquez, Ingres, Bonnard, and others.

The pictorial language of Botero evokes the musical language of Mozart. If indeed it's true that Mozart didn't formally invent opera, church music, or the symphony, it's also true that what we hear is unmistakably Mozart. Even the most untrained ear can detect Mozart's style, his unique way of endowing his music with rigor and sensuality.

Mozart composed Mozart with every piece of music he wrote while using all the preexisting codification. He didn't create his own code. The creation of one's own code is a contradiction that is nipped in the bud, because a code that is only one person's code would be unable to elicit a particular feeling in someone else. Genius, for sure, brings a new dimension to what we hear, but a work of art has to be perceptible before we can speak of its communicativeness.

The study of codes, which includes the grammar, syntax, concept, and theory of colors, does not allow for the recognition of that which sparks or doesn't spark the emotion that results from a particular use of color. To square ourselves with the ontology of Aristotle, we should state that studies of aesthetic theory don't go beyond the sphere of essences. They refer the individual to that which is universal, uniting what is formal with what is material. They even separate the principle of their conjunction. What is *fundamental* and essential, however, is not given expression.

There is something ineffable that defies words, but that one knows, and there is also an excessiveness that has nothing to do with mysticism. It's the final causality of the singular thing that is more and better than the essence of that which is seen. It is this very essence in action, captured at its peak in a *concrete form*. The τό τί ην εἶναι of Aristotle, "the *being* that *was being*" expresses the perfection of a passage from the power of action, the perfection of rendering presence. The perfection of ren-

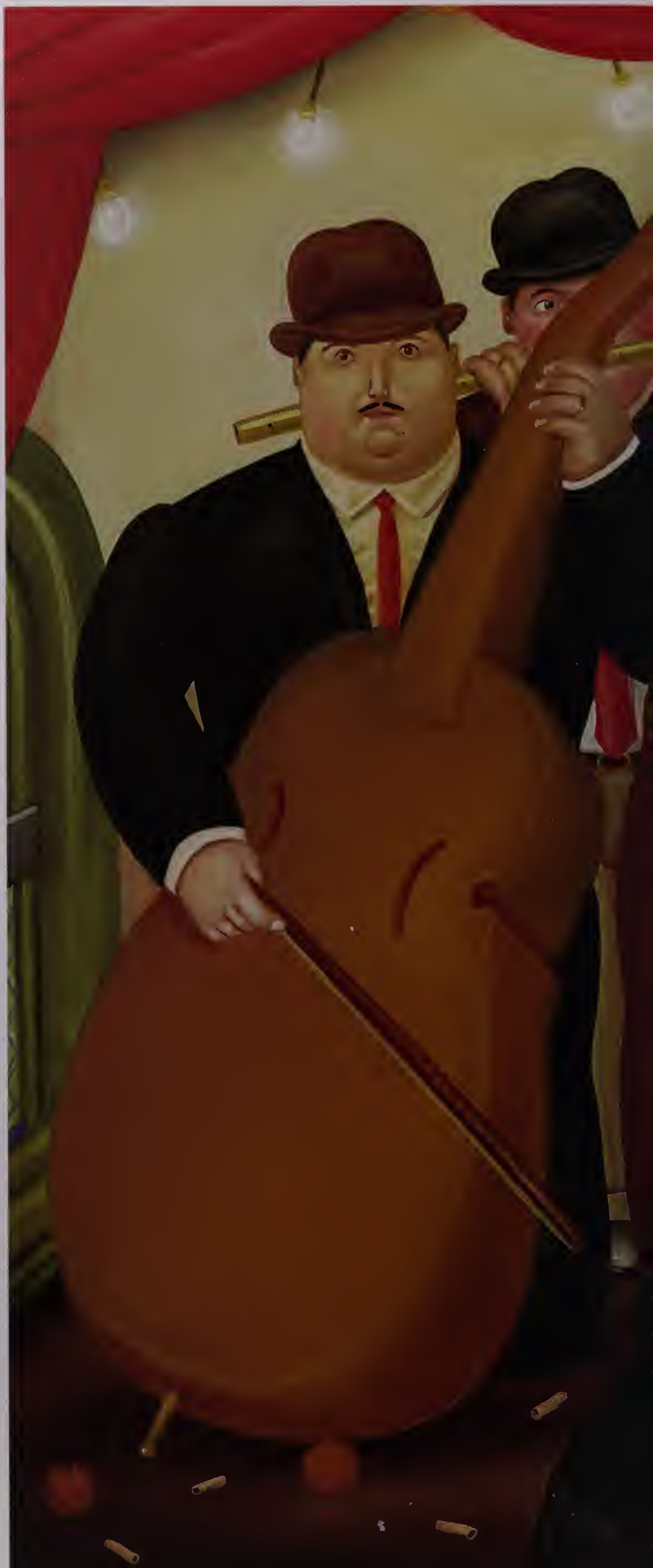
IV style and communication without concept

* Cf. Biographical information on page 139 of this work.

dering presence looks at the essential imperfection of that which can only be imperfect in the ideal sense. It also expresses, beyond all distinctive signs, a superlative unity and an ineffable happiness beyond individual happiness, that $\tau\acute{o}$ $\delta\acute{e}$ $\tau\acute{\iota}$, and not "something else," that in no way functions against other things, but with them. The successful work doesn't separate. It gathers together. It uses its power of attraction from that within it that is irreducible and totally unique.

In morality as in art, it's not a matter of being exemplary or even setting a good example. On the contrary, it's a matter of transcending in the here and now that which governs the relationships of law and their particular instances. The desire to imitate that which is inimitable is induced only through the accession of the statute of the model. Botero was more aware of this than anyone, and in this sense his remakes of the old Masters are inimitable imitations of the inimitable.

In order to clarify this point we have just mentioned Aristotle, who thought in terms of final causality. Another way of expressing Aristotle's thought would be in terms of a reason for existing as a half-way mark, a summit between the two extremities of birth and death. For Aristotle, "being" is in no way "being-for-death" or "being" for the end of things in the twofold sense of today's meaning: fulfillment and termination. "Being" for Aristotle was solely in the sense of fulfillment, the duration of that which is best in the presence that radiates from the thing itself. It is not good if language refers only to itself, as it does in sophistry and even sometimes in Plato's



76. *Ball in Colombia*, 1980, 180 x 231 cm, oil on canvas.





77. *Mlle. Rivière*, 1973, 192 x 138
cm, oil on canvas.

grand idealism. It's preferable if language knows itself to be *measured* by that which is to be expressed. When this is applied in parallel manner to painting, it is best that painting finalize its solid investigation of what is sentient based on that which communicates subjectivity, and not just on self-reference. Botero's painting does this. It is an investigation into subjective communication that is undertaken in and through essence and beyond essence, but in no way against essence. One could say that Botero's painting is without $\upsilon\beta\rho\iota\sigma$, without the surrealistic delirium or an enthusiasm for anything gestural or insignificant.

Botero's work is presented in an almost Aristotelian reaction to that which one could refer to as the sophistry of contemporary painting, and in particular, contemporary American painting. Botero was a counter-current in his fight against the cult of insignificance, against the unleashing of organic lines that blindly lash out in all directions with neither a beginning nor a center, and without any relationship between them except that of collage, which would be better expressed as pillage! Botero was adamantly against this patchwork of North American "culture" with its apparent attempt to confection some sort of unifying artistic principle or to give birth to a manner of being that has nothing to do with Europe . . .

Thus far, this attempt has not born fruit. The Americans are still the barbarians of Europe. They haven't yet gone from the "Romanesque" period to their "Gothic" period. They haven't yet profoundly changed the principles and have merely welcomed and digested the ef-



78. *Pre-Columbian Pottery*, an Olmec figurine: 1300 to 800 B.C.E., ceramic in white and cream enamel, Museum of Primitive Arts, New York.



79. *Three Musicians*, 1983, 163 x 123 cm, oil on canvas.

fects of these principles at that. What they have done is to cut off these so-called effects from their organic origins. In other words, to use the language of Deleuze, they have "deterritorialized" that which they have taken, but the result of their abstract and boastful manipulations has not yet recreated a way of being that is entirely autonomous. American superiority is in the realm of defense, finance and high-tech. It is neither artistic nor philosophic.

As a young Colombian in New York, who was perhaps as influenced by the zoomorphic and anthropomorphic forms found in Quimbaya pottery as he was inspired by Italian and Spanish art, Botero was, from the outset, at odds with the abstract bitterness of the art of Rothko and Pollack, which was then most popular. Unifying his Colombian roots with the great art of the Italian Renaissance, Botero's painting espouses a finality. This finality is not in the invention of a self-referencing language, but rather in an opening up to the object. It is in the glorification of simplicity and in the magnification of life in all its shapes and colors. For those painters who were reducing the essence of painting to the rules of one of the current trends, or for those who obstinately believed that shifting rules of painting was the equivalent of shifting rules in geometry or developing new computer programs, Botero's work was considered as either "retro" or as "genre painting."

Painting, however, is capturing the antecedence of that which is sentient in a form that is able to move people emotionally. It's this very subjectivity with regard to the contemplated object that Botero's work always retains and

communicates. Botero at first tested objects by returning to that which is sentient, that which is sealed within objects. He then returned this element of sentience to what is visible much in the same way one would turn a glove or a sock inside out. It's the very same sentience that all aesthetic theories dissimulate or, even worse, censor for being simultaneously too primitive and too spiritual, too low-brow and too high-brow.

Sentience is a source of numerous possibilities that is honored in the work of Botero. He reveals it and communicates it. This communication is not on the level of logic. It is subjective and assumes a structure of receptivity in the viewer that is not blind to that which is sentient. It addresses the viewer whose receptivity does not repress or dissimulate the simple and overwhelming power of subjectivity.

Herein lies the difficulty. All attempts to structure receptivity or all schematization of intuition function like a repressive code, or at least as a selective principle or filter that allows only a minute part of things to pass through and enter while sacrificing the rest. It's possible to show the "rest" without taking prejudice and habit into account: Just close your eyes and leave yourself open to chance or coincidence. This was a temptation* for Surrealism, but it characterizes to a greater extent so-called "Action Painting." Action Painting merely touches on the emptiness of its existence, and instead of appearing in its full richness, doesn't go beyond the generalities, generally remaining in the stage of a rough draft. What is excessive is indicated as excess, but instead of being

excessive, it is merely decorative. To be excessive it's necessary to go through the selective process of receptivity.

Excessiveness unites with receptivity only to modify it, constrain it from growing and expanding, and to experience what it lacks in and of itself in an abstract way—in a social way, or in a light-headed and contented way. Botero knew how to do this: He slipped that which censors this code into the code of the Renaissance, and from then on, we, as Renaissance decedents, or Europeans, learn that the Renaissance not only didn't see it all, but that there's plenty more to see that's still concealed. He showed us that there's plenty of "newness," as well.

It is still quite timely to see bananas and onions in a way that we've never seen them before. It is still possible to be affected by the simplicity of things that are suddenly made manifest in a superior way, and endowed with consummate balance. In Botero's work, objects regain their full preponderance, their full being. Botero reendowed form with the preponderance that representational painting had deprived it of. He structured his canvases in a way that presented "presence." He captured that which from within objects could render them splendid. His was an innocent splendor that was expertly elaborated!

* The word "temptation" is used on purpose. André Masson understood this. Neither Max Ernst, Miró, Magritte, nor Dalí used it.



80. *Homage to Bonnard*, 1973,
248 x 187 cm, oil on canvas.

Botero knew that the anatomy of a canvas is not the same as the anatomy of form. He knew that there is an irreducible difference between the world that he captured and the capturing of the world. This difference is what makes the noncomplimentary transposition of the world possible in his capturing of it. A painting never becomes an external reality. It is never allowed to become degraded into an object. That which is painted becomes a painting, but the state of being painted is not modified. What is modified is the way in which things affect us, and not the things in themselves.

It's never what moves us that is captured. Instead, it's the emotion or subjectivity itself. This is done through the skilled simulation of the object, thanks to the construction of an illusion that refers back to possibility as possibility, as sentience. It is dissimulated in a perceptive selection, and once the possibility is fulfilled, it's forced to disappear. It's censored. The problem is to accomplish this censorship while acting to counter it, while bringing back into visibility that which is not visible.

In order for this return of "dansity" to be at work and in the work, and in order for that which is obscure to find a place for itself in the center of visibility that it renders possible, pictorial visibility must be of a different nature than organic visibility. Art is able to accomplish that which nature cannot. Painting takes hold of an excess that perception transforms into being, and from that point on it continually dissimulates or conceals it. It is true that nonpictorial

perception of something evokes the imaginary in its own way, given that we see objects or beings, and not images. We reflect on images, or as Heidegger would express it, we "re-flect"; we aim towards a previous image of a chair or a jug with the intent of transcending the image to approach the being of the thing.

This ecstatic or phantasmagorical transcendence towards an ontological consistence is in no way indicated by the appearance of the thing itself. It is our belief in what is visible that supplies our lack of certainty with regard to the statute of the thing's "being." We can also refer to this as "ontico-phenomenological" belief.

In one sense, however, painting destroys this type of ontological certitude *ipso facto*. It forbids us to imagine the invisibility of a thing's "being" at whim. It goes so far as to inscribe its being on the canvas and reveal that which must be seen of what is invisible. This is part of the subversive nature of painting and is specific to its *modus operandi*. Painting modifies the perception of things by inscribing a pictorial code into perceptibility that otherwise would be perceived only as opaque outlines, or as receding. Painting exercises a healthy constraint on the inherent phantasmagorical constraint of perception. In Botero's work, this constraint doesn't take place outside of habitual perception. It works on perception and juxtaposes itself to it, often seeming to mold with it or to share its way of seeing. This, however, is only to better betray

it, to dislocate it in a more certain way from its pseudo-natural proclivities. Take for example Botero's *Ecce Homo*

V form as
absence
presence and
of sentience

(1969). How could someone change their idea about Christ after seeing this painting? It is always with this painting that the dislocation takes place, be it "for" or "against." With a positive response, we would henceforth think less of the conceptual intelligence of the Passion when Christ was evoked, and instead think more of all the flesh and sentience that ascetic triumphs entail. Sentience has been overly neglected in the Christian faith!

So much flesh has been hidden behind all those rites and theological arguments! So much fanaticism has gone into this slavish belief that unreservedly praises the resurrection of bodies and affirms that what is impossible is possible! How, therefore, after seeing *Ecce Homo* can someone return to what is imagined of faith without rekindling the disagreement that occurred between the architect Brunelleschi and the sculptor Donatello that began when the latter attributed the body of a peasant boy to the body of Christ! Since then, there have been visions of Christ by Dali, Bacon, and . . . Botero.

Each one of us has an idea of the Christ that is more or less stereotypical, more or less marked by the interpretation of myth. In this particular sense, it is quite remarkable that painting, as Hegel saw it, was so filled with indecision with regard to the joining of the Christian phenomenon with Neoplatonic necessity to interpret what is spiritual based on sentience. Christianity demands a phenomenological vision of that which is sentient, a Revelation that would not only have no legitimate model in the visible world but no model anywhere else either. This is a contra-



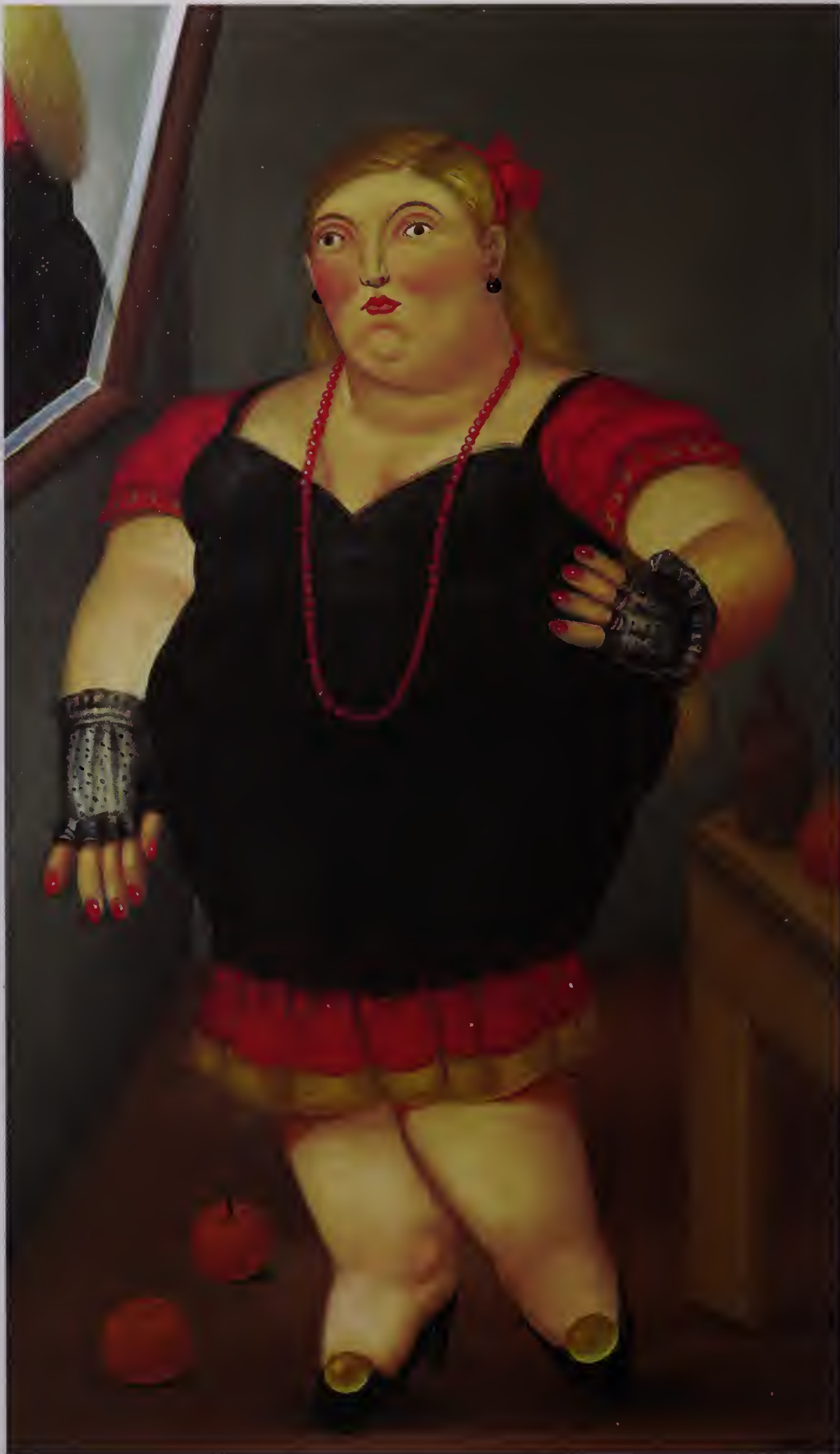
81. *Tryptic (Mater Dolorosa)*, 1969, 250 x 148 cm, oil on canvas.



82. *Tryptic (Ecce Homo)*, 1969, 250 x 148 cm, oil on canvas.



83. *Tryptic (Centurion)*, 1969, 250 x 148 cm, oil on canvas.



84. *Woman*, 1980, 107 x 89 cm,
oil on canvas.

diction in terms of painting, and it is also a contradiction of the same type in all of Christianity*!

For every Christian, it is indeed a matter of patterning a model of the Christ in terms of what is given in the Gospels, a text that demands careful interpretation and active comprehension, as do all written texts. This imaginary model has been more or less stratified by various religious orthodoxies. If the continued imitation of this model is adhered to, it can nonetheless be modified in its form without ceasing to be valid in its excessive permanence. It is necessary for Jesus, man *and* God, to be more than a man without losing his humanness. The divine excess must find a way of becoming manifest in that which is human. What is divine is indeed imagined, but imaged or presented according to the principle of formation that is unique to Botero. This principle of formation inflects the eye towards a dimension of myth that is in no way typical.

When evoked with and "for" Botero, the Christ ceases to be emaciated and affects us according to a form that captures from sentience a part that has been censored by classical representation. It's that part that basically doesn't exist.

Where is the Christ most adequately formed? In Carpaccio's *Meditation*, or in Crivelli, where the convulsed gasps of suffering are portrayed as if surrounded by a devouring and unhealthy solicitude? Or is it in the coded stylization of Byzantine art, or in Russian icons? Or is it perhaps in movies that feature the facial traits of Max von Sydow or Terence Stamp?

There are a thousand and one



85. *Nun-baby*, 1975, 94 x 130 cm, oil on canvas.

86. *Woman with Necklace*, 1983, oil on canvas.

* An example of this effacement is the anecdote according to which the painter Estève, in the course of a dinner, asked that a Botero painting be removed from his presence. His wish was granted. The power of disturbance is the greatest honor a painter could pay to his fellow painter, and best emphasizes how strongly the incriminated work could disturb.



paths that are magnetized to what is concealed. They are simultaneously cultivated and rebuffed. The unity of the Revelation, except for the identity of the being, is a myth. This dual movement of revelation and concealment, this "Yes, it's Him" and "No, it's not Him" had a powerful influence on Botero.

It's important to reiterate the "with and for" of Botero's Christ, as a return of sentence to a code that is too abstract or not sufficiently incarnate. However, "with and against" him, it's also possible to attribute this sentence to an ironic excess in which one tries to limit the impact by saying "No! A thousand times no. It's not possible. The God who was made a man could never look like that!"

"For": The Revelation must be reinterpreted and readjusted to the vision of the painter, who through his work gets mixed in with our own sensibilities and affects us. "Against": It is once again necessary to reinterpret, but this time it is to reenforce or to repeat the accepted logic, not only according to one's own nature, but according to a polemical preoccupation that involves wanting to remove from view the figurative enormity that Botero endowed his subject with.*

For or against, the impact of Botero's style is undeniable. He brings back or converts the thing to itself, although appearing only to respect or honor it. While espousing the laws of pictorial communication, Botero forced these laws to communicate in a phantasmatic figuration (not to be confused with "fantasy" or with the "fantastic") that came forth from the blank canvas, leaving all codes behind and thus spreading affec-

tive and rebellious forces all over. There is neither syntax nor words to describe the effect of the affective force, because it escapes all language. It is woven with the excess that accompanies descriptive language, but it can't be captured by it.

The singular form propagated in the works of Botero since his Mexican experience became increasingly present, contaminating everything to its own benefit. This form was unleashed in the highest artistic spheres in order to impose itself, as something that had been previously lacking in great works of art, but was henceforth revealed as the truest of all Truth. Toppling the heights of what was possible, Botero inscribed his monumental and figurative forms under the guise of what was real. He outrightly transformed *his* vision of the world into a vision of the World, a general vision that was valid for or against each person, be it as it may, but that was undeniably valid.

Whether one adheres to or rejects this is of no importance. What counts is that one is confronted with *creation*, which is evaluated in relationship to tradition. The "traditionalists" appreciate the craftsmanship that Botero demonstrated and praise the extensiveness of his visual culture. Some, however, stubbornly see sarcastic insolence and misplaced humor in his work. These are the sad zealots of erudition who become distraught or indignant the moment they're faced with someone who's neither a "follower" or a "copyist."

There are "modernists," or those of the avant-garde, who praise Botero for the same reasons that make the traditionalists detest him. Other modernists hate him and ac-



* On this issue, cf. our analyses in *Ossuaire de l'Esprit* [Catacombs of the Mind] (Ed. Difference) and in *Les quarante jours du Christianisme* [Forty days of Christianity] (Discordance).

88. *Poodle*, 1970, 102 x 81 cm, oil on canvas.



cuse him of prolonging a pictorial tradition that they intend to put to rest once and for all, or if not, that they intend to undermine. However, how does one cut oneself off from something that one was able to understand, from something that one wasn't obliged to be or to become?

Tributes and criticisms alike are interwoven into a network of misunderstandings that don't take into account the questions of Botero's style. Nor do they probe the question of how and by what means a work of art acts on another individual, how it modifies the way in which this "other" is affected in his vision of things and of the world.

All style is connected to a mode of formation, a formative horizon that allows it to be understood. This allows for variations, but these variations are related to the structure to such an extent that they modify it, or even blend with it completely. An investigation becomes a style when the rule ceases to be distinguished from the particular instance of the rule, when the use of the code is found "signed" or marked in all of the signs and in all movements of these signs. We've looked at the effects of "Boteromorphism" applied to the Christ form, but a similar analysis would be valuable not only with regard to the sentience of Botero's bishops, but for his soldiers, as well. As the writer Celine said: "When soldiers are not killing people, they're just like children."

Portrait of the Military Junta also reveals an aspect of things that are usually hidden. By putting what is derisive into the forefront, Botero makes us consider pomp and circumstance with a more lucid and less trustful eye. We

89. *Dictator's Son*, 1969, 97 x 135 cm, oil on canvas.



90. *The President*, 1975, 125 x 172 cm, pastel.

91. *Portrait of the Military Junta*, 1971, 174 x 218 cm, oil on canvas.







can never over-emphasize that Botero willfully brought his subjects closer to the sentience they possess, but that as "subjects," being only that which they are, the sentience that they also conceal.

To bring into light the darkness that conceals things and beings assumes that there's a style or an art that in one gesture conserves an "identifying" pictorial syntax. Doubled or deported from the inside by a syntax of sentience, primal effect, or difference, this syntax communicates with and against the syntax that precedes it. With Botero this figurative syntax is translated into Form. This "form" undergoes an internal push, and in this way conserves what would otherwise be hidden or concealed in "orthodox" or traditional use of classical or realist perspective. The convocation of this inner force, which is so characteristic of Botero's style, modifies the idea of proportion, and governs the distribution of planes on the canvas. It also makes the line that snakes its way towards an absent center relate to a combination of colors whose contrasts also provoke an impression of profound thickness.

The capturing of sentience is so heavily invested in the organization of the canvas that the canvas becomes totally emmeshed in the intensity that governs its own economy of means.

When Botero began to paint, he worked from the laws of composition that had been previously elaborated by the Cubists and the Renaissance. His signing of works did not yet indicate the direction his work would take, but it did show a certain promise and commitment. From the outset, Botero was really signing a

pact he had made with himself in relationship to painting. This pact took shape in a figurative form that went against the laws of composition, but that bended to or blended into these laws, even though it did so in a more or less abruptly contrasted way. In the broad terms of Western painting Botero was only a particular case when he began. He applied the rules and only barely deformed them. His borrowing in the early stages was a dominant pictorial constraint that predominated over what would be unique to his work and what would be his creative challenge.

The birth of Botero's style was a progressive inversion in the relationship of proportion between the essential rules of painting and the singular and fundamental exceptions to these rules. The arrival of his style thus blends into the moment where his singularity takes predominance over the universal laws of painting and its individual instances. This singular dominance in no way supplants the essence. The laws of painting are still there, but in and beyond them Botero affirmed his own imprint. A productive spontaneity allowed Botero to make Boteros in the same way that a tree bears fruit.

Botero's victories over that which is invisible and his unfaithfulness to the status quo have nothing of what already existed. They were each innovative and novel. From this moment on, not one aesthetic category was able to incorporate his work except in negative terms. At this point Botero became himself, and he had a way of painting that was unclassifiable.

It's possible to prove this affirmation of self through attempting to summarize Bo-

tero's work by using the two most important aesthetic concepts: "the beautiful" and "the poetic." There is no argument when his works are gathered under the ideal of beauty, given that they actualize that which is sentient in a formal stability and give visual sensation the opportunity to join with what is excessive. Far from being trapped in a photographic immediacy, the viewer's eye takes pleasure in letting itself be carried by the form, and goes into a free play mode during the course of its contemplation.

Despite the clarity and serenity in Botero's works, there is also an element of anxiety. The works seem to contradict or disavow their own perfection, sometimes giving the feeling of precariousness or excessiveness. Botero didn't flinch in front of the horrors of this world. Instead he transcended them. A case in point is the dog that is playing with the head of a little girl, or with the self-satisfied pose of the "conquistador," killer of Indians. Likewise, the utter simplicity of Botero's themes, be it his reworking of Velasquez or the formality of a group portrait (the family or musicians), doesn't obfuscate the simplicity of the resulting effect. One could say, as a matter of fact, that the delicacy, weakness or vulnerability of his subjects contribute to the strength of his work. His rabbits are filled with alacrity. Their poses and leaps contribute to a feeling of monumentality that comes through the whole of the canvas with its trees and hunters, while the reflection in the water introduces the traces of a reflection in the pictorial reflection. Without losing any of its balance, "the beautiful" in Botero's work often has the



93. *Hunter*, 1982, 126 x 154 cm
oil on canvas.





appearance of allying itself with the bizarre. One might say that he shows a knowing shyness, or he adds to his mastery a deliberate sarcasm.

There is beauty then, but with an ironic aspect, that is to say, a mocking glance often delegated to the animals that inhabit this strange universe. The immediate stability of pictorial forms is counterbalanced by a sort of remembrance colored with an odd humor that derives perhaps from Pre-Columbian art. At the same time one must be a bit careful because what appears to European eyes as exotic and charming often stems from roots deep in the soil of Latin American culture. That which appears anecdotal can come out of a logical coherence that governs all daily life. This point of view is definitively considered in Vargas Llosa's important study. (Botero, *dessins et aquarelles*. La Difference—L'Autre Musée, Paris, 1984.)

This work demonstrates how the Latin Americaness of Botero integrates Andean reality with Western perspectives and in what ways his work develops rapports and functions as a bridge between two worlds. One thinks, for example, of Quimbayan pottery whose plump anthropomorphism is completed by handles that are sorts of little hands or arms or the most popular feminine ideal of the "beautiful fat lady" or the "deceptively thin lady"; it's clear that Botero's work is not at all limited to one or another stereotype. His work in no way lends itself to be summarized by one idea of beauty only.

Botero's works are more than beautiful. In this sense they are beautiful in the romantic notion of ideal beauty. His



95. *Church*, 1982, 117 x 83 cm, oil on canvas.

works are "poetic." With Botero, formal balance includes disorientation, a form of nostalgia that, in turn, is drawn towards a past moment in time, or towards a far-away part of his homeland. In their orientation towards that which is sentient in the mystery of things, the works of Botero take into account an active absence. In this process of revelation there is not only enthusiasm but ardent spirit. Botero's bullfights, his groups of musicians, his smiling still lifes, all reveal his penchant for a metaphysical romanticism, but once again this heroism of the mind inevitably finds itself strapped with ambiguity.

It's as if Botero suspended all pantheistic communion in the oblique dimension of the path that lead there. He contradicts all feelings of anguish or melancholy through an internal distancing, through a bitter-sweet lucidity. In communicating what is felt, he maintains the traces of a certain reflection. The praise of that which is simple and popular is replete with critical acuity. In other words, Botero's populist aspect has something elegant and aristocratic about it. He slipped a form of chilly politeness into the heart of naïve joy, as if he was pondering his adherence to this joy, or keeping up his guard with regard to it. The purest flights of innocence in his paintings are not exempt from a certain comic element. There are also touches that prove a certain seriousness of mind. Symbiosis with sentience is therefore never total. Botero is too much in the thick of mediation to be drawn in by the beautiful illusions of immediacy.

Botero's magic is too controlled, too refined to give into romanticism or to realism. He

would never submit without a fight to the harness of one trend or another. Thus, his idea of beauty has a strain of ironic reserve running through it. Likewise, his romanticism is charged with a self-criticism that keeps him at equal distance from all naïveté and from all mysticism. It also keeps him at arm's length from all savagery and from all imprecision. European Romanticism didn't fare well in the luminosity of marble, in the taste for the monumental, or in broad daylight. However, aside from a clarity of affirmation and an expert balance in Botero's romanticism, there's a critical eye at work that's somewhat akin to Cervantes's knowing that Don Quixote is nothing except a fictional character, the subject of a novel.

There's too much of the monumental in Botero for him to have allowed himself to be seduced by that which is evanescent. He was too oriented towards mineral life to cultivate mist and clouds in his paintings. He was not at all a man of the North, even if his paintings do have an extremely rigorous vein. Botero's work is, therefore, neither "beautiful" in the classical sense, nor "poetic" in the romantic sense. Nonetheless, it participates in both with sovereign ease. Nonetheless, it pleases and it touches.

Botero's work illustrates such singular concreteness that we can exhaust ourselves in following it and in weaving formulas around it. Regardless of how refined these formulas appear, his characters and revelations escape them. The hands of Botero's characters are most often small, short-fingered and chubby. It's as if the massiveness of the forms was not exempt from a higher



96. *The Patio*, 1982, 175 x 113 cm,
oil on canvas.



sense of modesty, as if signaling or including a something concealed. This is another instance of the transpictorial dimension of Botero's work. With the exception of Ingres, or more recently of Delvaux, Botero seemed to deny himself the absolute suppression of the subject in the anatomy of the painting. He gives the subject the opportunity to remain vital, to react to the painter's eye, like a clam reacts to lemon juice. The disturbing thickness that he endows his subjects with goes hand in hand with an attribute of vulnerability, a revelation of weakness or of gentle abandon.

Sentience that makes the return to visibility often bears the characteristics of childhood. Sometimes it even includes the fetal state. The hands, breasts, genitals, mouths, and eyes are small, as if the areas of the body that express desire had been shrunk. In this way, they expose or express a strange hesitation. Through the action of the pictorial eye they seem to lose all erotic potential. The love scenes are bathed in an atmosphere of joviality. The lovers are painted either before or after the sexual act. The atmosphere is pleasant, but not at all charged with sexual desire. It's quite clear that the sensuality of the painting is above all pictorial and is quite different from the sensuality that draws the sexes together in real life. The forms have an androgynous aspect about them. Even more, there's a manner of sublimation in the way they are presented, as if being delved more deeply than the mere difference between the sexes.

This arrival of sentience into light magnifies and aggrandizes. It renders eternal that

97. *Portrait of Mr. and Mrs. Thomas Messer*, 1968, 185 x 150 cm, oil on canvas.



98. *Primping*, 1982, 143 x 119 cm.
oil on canvas.

99. *Still Life with Coffee Pot*, 1977,
150 x 186 cm, oil on canvas.









101. *Still Life with Pineapples*,
1971, 164 x 193 cm, oil on
canvas.



102. *The Lovers*, 1984, 167 x 128
cm, oil on canvas.

which cannot be captured. This is true of the movement of the dancers as they pirouette on an axis that is so solid that everything is condensed into it. It's as if the very rhythm of the dance was instantaneously expressed and, once and for all, frozen in the relationship between the hands and feet. This is also true of the Church encircled with red lines and crowned with a small cross that underlines what is essential—the massiveness of the walls and the englobing nature of architectural form. In Botero's homages to Bonnard it becomes clear that Botero never allowed form to be attached to that which was evanescent. No doubt that this is why Botero became such a marvelous sculptor, opposing his formal perfection to conventions of Egyptian, Greek, and Renaissance sculpture.

At the height of his art, it seems that Botero could do everything, not only sculpture, but modeling in marble or bronze. He invented unique principles that rendered form to contain everything, including space. He captured his characters at the moment their gestures were most furtive. This is true in the case of his dancers and his bullfights, and is evident in the gesture of the man holding his mistress on his knee, as well. The strength and formal opulence in no way contradict the tender and delicate nature of the caress, which is barely traced and which touches on the only element of clothing that is worn by the loved one—her earring. For those who know how to see, herein lies the entire mystery of painting. These monumental forms are capable of capturing gracefulness. The saturation of what is visible is so complete that it re-

verses itself. It lifts a corner of the curtain of visibility, and seems to offer the mind its true challenge: to express what "being" is, to understand the meaning of artistic creation, where that which one should be able to think is stored. Botero continued to reveal this. He continued to render this eternal.

Botero rendered to sentience its full measure. In doing so, he also emphasized its absence and concealment. Thanks to him we can see what is necessary to conceptualize. But we don't just see and remain silent. With Botero's works, philosophy learns to draw closer to that which unveils itself to the circumlocutions of conceptual thought. This happens to a greater extent when the concealment is counterbalanced by an extraordinary talent, a richness that is so great it prohibits the other side of the mirror from exposing this conceptual thought. Everything is seen, everything is insinuated, but none of it is transparent. Nothing of this mystery is comprehensible. Nothing about this necessity has been brought to light, except for the possibility that it can be brought to light, except for the crazy need to understand the meaning of this world, of artistic creation, of death and of life. Without art life and death would be deprived of humanity. Artistic creation mixes so well with the humanity of man that through it we have an equivalent to "thinking mankind," to capturing its essence. Until now this essence has been misunderstood. Until now it has been divided between the part of sentience that is offered and the part of sentience that is uncovered or revealed. There are no words

to describe the movement of this primal unity that Botero's forms recreate with mythical sovereignty.

Botero's painting, like the totality of painting, incarnates the triumph of myth over philosophy. This is why it's important that we don't let the body of his work pass us by without questioning it. The absence of attention to it would also be philosophical blindness. This blindness would be as definitive under the yoke of science and sophistry as it would under the yoke of religious belief and fanaticism. We have perhaps never measured and calculated as much and thought as little as we do today. It's a good thing that Botero's paintings have that out-sized quality. Mystery and spiritual provocation are good, and for this reason it is good that the creative act exists.



103. *Our Lady of Colombia*, 1967.
208 x 195 cm, oil on canvas.

We have shown how Botero's work pictorially embodies the ineffable quality of sentience through figurative solidity and through the creation of multiple levels. Without concept this pictorial embodiment communicates in depth with human sensitivity. This communication is operative not only through what Botero was able to capture from his native Colombia but also in ways more complete and more powerful. Colombia, one of the most beautiful and most dangerous countries in the world, is in truth totally appropriated in his work. He did much more than give Colombia an image that's technically worthy of Renaissance painting. He did much more than open a window on the essence of that which is Latin American. He exposed a vision that every Colombian can identify with! Botero will go down in history as one of the founders of Colombian culture. It's through him that this young country expresses its most positive vision of itself, and each individual in Colombia seems to experience this. He was truly loved by his fellow Colombians. The enthusiasm for Botero's public appearances was overwhelming. He was surrounded by crowds clamoring for his autograph, or by simple people just crying out his name in the streets. Once, while sitting amidst the crowd at a bullfight in Bogotá, a doll vendor cried out from his heart: "Fernando Botero! . . . Good Afternoon!" The painter turned around and said to me: "That to me is worth all the books in the world. It is better than all the honors!"

Botero, a living myth, one of

the most sensitive human beings possible, was never happier than when he was in Medellín, in the neighborhoods of his childhood among those proud souls who were the poorest of the poor. He was at home in the tiny mountain restaurants where there was always joyous music and an incomparable nobility. He was at home in the streets of El Retiro where the abject misery of certain houses was proudly hidden by garlands of flowers. The legitimate disproportion that we have spoken of, and of which Botero made stunning stylistic use, is in perfect accordance with the excesses of his Colombian homeland.

Everything there seems exaggerated: the mangoes, the orchids, the giant ferns, the carnivorous plants, and even male chauvinism. Take for instance the distinguished man who squeezes his wife so hard in his arms that he breaks one of her ribs. Take for example the churches that range from the purest or most severe simplicity to the most total ornate brilliance. Or take perhaps the most well-behaved people who dance among the cars or stroll about half-naked, draped only in a blanket. This magic that an entire country identifies with is marvelous. It speaks to every layer of Colombian society with incomparable fervor. The wealthiest buy Botero's canvases, and the poorest would ask him to sign the reproductions of these paintings printed in the local newspapers. From gastronomic clubs to matador associations, from shoe-shine boys to the President of the Republic, there is unanimity in the admiration for Botero.

Botero has done more than bring the Colombians closer to their heritage. He has also

VI colombia seen through its own eyes



given an enduring image of his country to the rest of the world. If he were able to consolidate a Colombian image both within and outside of his country, it was because he had managed to make sentience shine forth at the very center of what is visible. In sentience resides the essence of what is human. It is from sentience that all true creativity originates and will continue to originate.

Without a similar plunge into the depths of what is sentient, no work of art can stand on its own. Painting can be successful without it, but will never be a glorious work of art. Botero is glorious. His work brings to light an orientation of the mind. Far from participating in the general dispersion of things, Botero's work creates the conditions for gathering and uniting what is essential. What is essential is something that philosophy could never abandon.



105. *Colombian Woman Eating an Apple*, 1982, 170 x 156 cm, oil on canvas.



106. *Teresita, the Cutter*, 1963, 21 x 155 cm, oil on canvas.
107. *Still Life with Falling Oranges*, 1978, 157 x 193 cm, oil on canvas.

biography of the artist

1932—Fernando Botero born in Medellín, Colombia, on April 19.

1948—Botero shows two aquarells at the Exposition de Pintores Antioquenos in Bogotá.

1951—Botero moves to Bogotá. His first one-man show, with Leo Matiz.

1952—Second one-man show with Leo Matiz. Walter Engel publishes Botero's first monograph with Eddy Torres editions in Bogotá. *Seafront* receives second prize at the Salon of Independent Colombian Artists. With the money that he is "allouce" as well as the money from the sales from his show, he decides to go to Europe. First he goes to Spain. He visits Barcelona, enrolling for a one-year course at the San Fernando Academy in Madrid. He studies the works of Velasquez and Goya at the Prado Museum. He's struck with admiration for a reproduction of *The Visit of the Queen of Sheba to King Solomon* by Piero della Francesca.

1953—Botero spends the summer in Paris. He prefers the Louvre Museum to the National Museum of Modern Art. In September he leaves for Italy and rents a studio in Florence. At the Academy of San Marco he studies the technique of fresco painting (Giotto, Andrea del Castagno) and sits in on the courses given by the art historian Roberto Longhi on the Italian Quattrocento and Renaissance. He visits Arezzo.

1955—Botero returns to Bogotá. His recent works are shown at the National Library, including those that he painted in Italy.

1956—Botero moves to Mexico. His studies lead him towards what will become his definitive style. He paints his first still life with mandolin.

1957—First stay in the United States for an exhibit of his work in Washington, D.C. He visits New York where the works of the abstract expressionist school of painting are in vogue.

1958—He lives in Colombia. *The Conjugal Bedroom (Homage to Mantegna)* [*La Camera degli sposi (Omaggio a Mantegna)*] receives the first prize at the 21st Salon in Bogotá. He teaches until 1960 at the Academy of Fine Arts in Bogotá.

1959—Botero participates in the 5th Biennale in Sao Paulo, Brazil. He paints *Mona Lisa Age Twelve*.

1960—Botero leaves for New York and takes a studio in Greenwich Village. He receives the Guggenheim Award for Colombia.

1961—The Museum of Modern Art in New York purchases *Mona Lisa Age Twelve*.

1964—*Apples* receives a prize at the First Intercol Salon for Young Artists, which is organized by the Museum of Modern Art in Bogotá. The beginning of the series of portraits of Madame Rubens.

1966—First one-man shows in Europe at the Kunsthalle in Baden-Baden, the Buchholz Gallery in Munich, and the Brusberg Gallery in Hanover.

1967—Travels to Italy and Germany where he looks at the works of Dürer, and produces a series of "fusains," which he signs *Dürerbotero*.

1969—Large pastels and drawings. Claude Bernard gives Botero his first exhibit in Paris.

1970—Klaus Gallwitz at the Buchholz Gallery in Munich publishes a Botero monograph. A traveling exhibit in five German museums of 80 of Botero's paintings.

1971—Botero takes a studio in Paris.

1972—Botero exhibits at the Marlborough Gallery in New York. He produces sanguines and chalk (charcoal?) on canvas and includes himself in *Dinner with Ingres and Piero della Francesca*.

1973—Botero lives in Paris. He's given a Retrospective of his works from 1948 to 1972 in Bogotá. Germán Arciniegas and Mario Rivero write separate monographs on him. The former is published by Ed-

ilerner in Madrid, and the latter by Plaza and Janes editions in Bogotá.

1976—A Retrospective of Botero at the Musuem of Contemporary Art in Caracas, Venezuela. Klaus Gallwitz writes a new monograph for Gerd Hatje editions in Stuttgart. Botero devotes 1976 and 1977 to sculpture. Claude Bernard exhibits Botero's watercolors and drawings in Paris.

1977—Botero donates 16 paintings to the Antioquia Museum in Medellín. Claude Bernard exhibits his first sculptures at the FIAC.

1978—Ursula Bode writes a monograph on Botero's sculpture for Brusberg Gallery editions.

1979—Several exhibits travel throughout the museums of Europe (Belgium, Norway, and Sweden) and the United States.

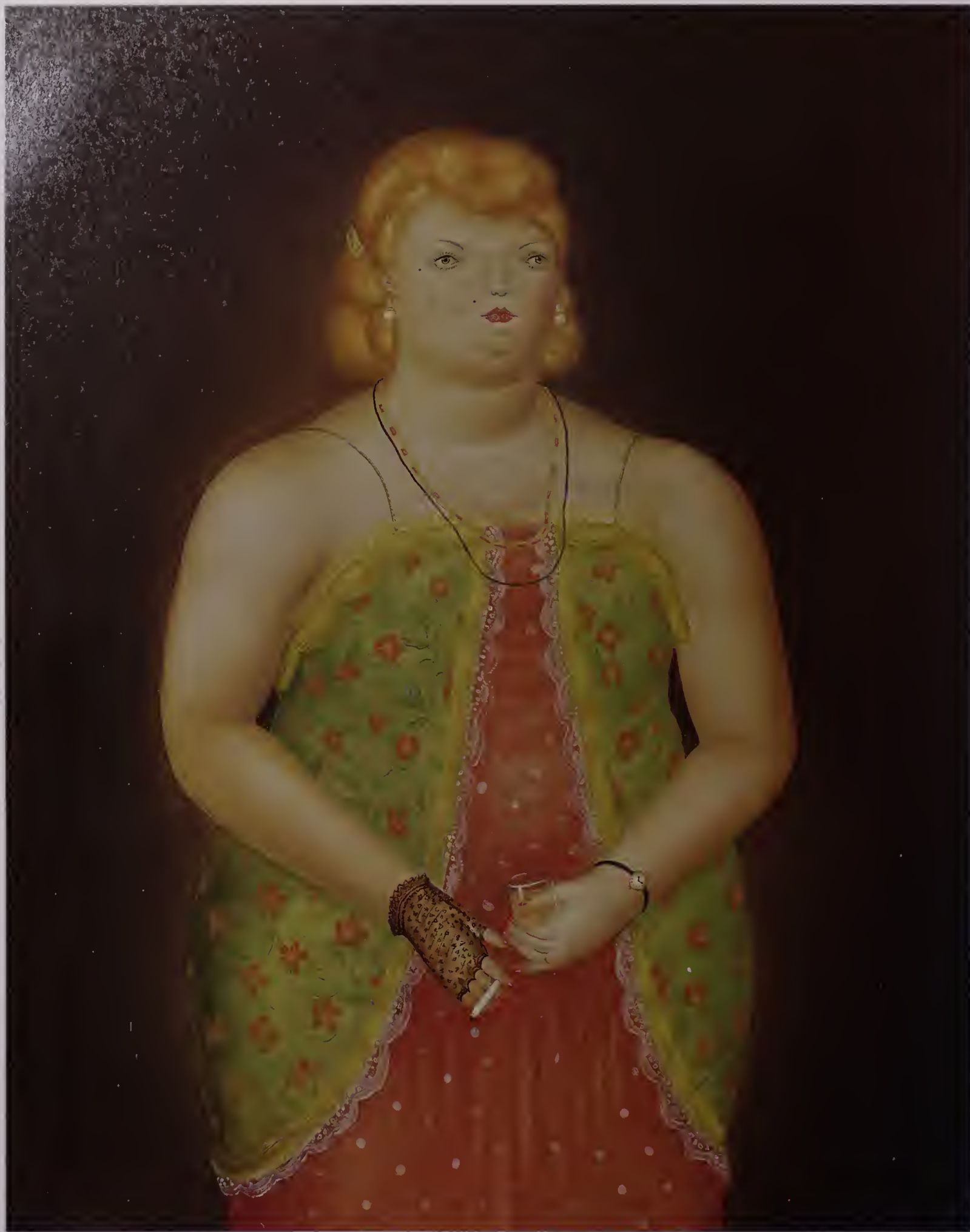
1980—Botero exhibits at the Beyeler Gallery in Bale, Switzerland. Carter Ratcliff's monograph on Botero is published by Abbeville Press in New York.

1981—A Botero Retrospective is presented by the Japanese in the Tokyo and Osaka museums.

1983—Botero splits his time between New York, Paris, and Tuscany. The Metropolitan Museum of Art in New York acquires one of his paintings for their permanent collection.

1984—Botero installs a new sculpture atelier in Pietrasanta, Italy. He donates sculptures to the Antioquia Museum in Medellín. A special Botero exhibition room is inaugurated in September.

1985—Botero exhibits a series of paintings entirely devoted to the bullfight at the Marlborough Gallery in New York.



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1952

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1955

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1957

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1958

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1959

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1960

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1961

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1962

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1964

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1965

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1968

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1969

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1970

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1972

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1973

Fernando Botero. Marlborough Galleria d'Arte, Rome. 10 April–8 May. Catalog. 17 works.

Fernando Botero: Retrospectiva 1948–1972. Colegio San Carlos, Bogotá. 23–27 January. Catalog text by Tracy Atkinson. 32 works.

1974

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Fernando Botero: Aquarelle und Zeichnungen. Galerie Brusberg, Hanover. 19 January–23 February. 44 works.

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1975

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1976

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Botero: Aquarelles et dessins. Galerie Claude Bernard, Paris. 18 March–28 April. Catalog text by Severo Sarduy. 41 works.

Fernando Botero. Museo de Arte Contemporáneo, Caracas. 2 April–3 May. Catalog text by Sofia Imber. 38 works.

1977

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1978

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1979–1980

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Fernando Botero. Hirshhorn Museum & Sculpture Garden, Washington, DC. 20 December 1979–10 March, 1980. Catalog text by Cynthia Jaffee McCabe. Also at Art Museum of South Texas, Corpus Christi, TX, 27 March–10 May 1980.

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1981

Seibu Museum of Art, Tokyo.

Osaka Municipal Museum of Fine Arts, Osaka.

Foire Internationale d'Art Contemporain (FIAC), Paris.

Il Gabbiano Galleria d'Arte, Rome.

1982

Recent Sculpture. Marlborough Gallery, New York.

Sculpture. Hooks-Epstein Gallery, Houston, TX.

Sculpture and Drawings. Hokin Gallery, Chicago.

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1983

Galerie Beyeler, Basel.

Sculpture. Thomas Segal Gallery, Boston.

Botero: Recent Sculpture. Fondation Veranneman.

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1984

Traveling Sculpture Exhibition: The Munson-Williams-Proctor Institute Museum of Art, Utica, NY; Everhard Museum, Scranton, PA; Herbert F. Johnson Museum of Art, Cornell University, Ithaca, NY; Purdue University, Lafayette, IN.



110. *The Botero Exhibit*. 1975, 52 x 196 cm, oil on canvas and collage.

111. *Love Letter*, 1968, 193 x 150 cm, oil on canvas.

Fernando Botero Sculpture, Chicago International Art Exposition, Marlborough Gallery, New York.

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1985

National Museum, Bogotá

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La Corrida: The Bullfight Paintings and Large Scale Sculpture, Marlborough Gallery, New York.

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1986

Museum of Contemporary Art, Caracas.

Botero: Bilder, Zeichnungen, Skulpturen, Kunsthalle der Hypo-Kulturstiftung, Munich; Kunsthalle, Bremen; Schirn Kunsthalle, Frankfurt.

Traveling Retrospective Exhibition in Japan: Tokyo Art Gallery, Tokyo; Hokkaido Museum of Modern Art, Sapporo; Daimaru Museum, Osaka; Niigata City Art Museum, Niigata.

Fernando Botero Drawings, Albany Museum of Art, Albany, GA, July 5–August 31.

1987

Pinturas, Dibujos, Esculturas, Centro de Arte Reina Sofía, Madrid.

Botero: La Corrida, Sala Viscontea-Castello Sforzesco, Milan.

Hokin Gallery, Palm Beach, FL.

Marlborough Fine Art, Tokyo.

1988

Botero, Casino Knokke, Knokke-Heist in conjunction with Galerie Beyler, Basel, Stichting/Fondation Veranneman-Kruishoutem.

Botero: La Corrida, Castell dell'Ovo, Naples and in the Albergo delle Povere in Palermo.

1989

Botero: La Corrida, Museo de Arte de Coro, Venezuela.

Botero: La Corrida, Museo de Arte Contemporaneo, Caracas.

Botero: La Corrida, Museo Rufino Tamayo, Mexico.

Fernando Botero: Bronzes & Drawings, Albert White Gallery, Toronto.

Fernando Botero, International Contemporary Art Fair, Los Angeles, Marlborough Gallery, New York.

1990

Botero: Peintures, Dessins, et Sculptures, Fondation Pierre Gianadda, Martigny, Switzerland.

Fernando Botero: Peintures—

Sculpture—Dessins, Fondation Veranneman, Belgium.

Fernando Botero: Recent Sculpture, Marlborough Gallery, New York.

1991

Botero: The Painter, Galerie Brusberg, Berlin.

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biography of the author

1947—Born in Jumet, Belgium, to Marcel Richard Oswald Paquet on February 21.

1960—Begins high school in the Latin and Greek curriculum at the Royal Athénée in the town of Gosse- lies. Follows the evolution of the massive strike that shakes Belgium.

1963—Reads Spinoza and Marx. Has a passion for literature and theatre. Plays the role of Gorgias in *Dyskolos* by Meander, which is presented in Gosselies and in Brussels. He travels to neighboring Holland. He reads Multatuli.

1964—He finishes high school, and moves to Brussels.

1965—Starts his studies in Roman philology; writes a short novel that is published under a pen name. Frequents extreme leftist groups, reads Boris Souverine, and writes a book of poetry, which he calls *The Sea (La Mer)*. The manuscript is lost.

1966—He registers as a philosophy student at Open University of Brussels.

1967—He's appointed as a teaching assistant, founds the review *Textures* with a group of friends, all of whom are students in philosophy and literature.

1968—Takes an active part in the student protests in Brussels, founds with Joaquim Vital and Alain Caneel *La Taupe* editions.

1969—He leaves the review *Textures* after a disagreement over a text that he wrote with Luc Richir. The text is published in number 9 of the review.

1970—He obtains his master's degree in philosophy. The subject of his master's thesis is "The problematic unity of Kantism in *The Critique of the Power of Judgement*." After much protest on the part of the academic authorities, he's appointed as an assistant in Philosophy.

1971—He is accepted as a researcher at the National Fund of Scientific Research in Belgium. Starts working on his doctorate.

1972—He writes an article on Hegel that catches the attention of

Gerard Lebrun and permits him to take Lebrun's place at the University of Tunis. During the two years he spends in Tunis, he gives courses on Kant, Hegel, Marx, and Nietzsche.

1974—He goes back to his research position at the F.N.R.S. and spends his time between Belgium and Paris.

1975—He becomes friendly with Patrick Waldberg, participates in the establishment of Editions de la Différence and works on the publication of *Demeures d'Hypnos*. He makes numerous trips to Italy. In Milan, Patrick Waldberg introduces him to The Marriage of the Virgin. He meets a lot of artists. He becomes friendly with Alexander Calder. He travels to New York and to Jerusalem.

1976—He publishes *L'Enjeu de la Philosophie (Philosophy's Stake)*. It gets good critical acceptance. He becomes friendly with Roger Munier. He goes to Poitiers to study the work of the philosopher Dom Deschamps.

1977—He moves back to Brussels, spends two years as the artistic director of a gallery where he exhibits the work of Nasser Assar, Balthus, Hans Bellmer, Cazac, Luigi Dalla Vigna, Labarthe, Andre Masson, Julio Pomar, Sandro Somare, etc.

1978—He gets his Ph.D. in philosophy with a thesis entitled "The Difference in Kantian and Hegelian Thought in Terms of the Essence of Art." Raymond Lacroix devotes positive articles to his publications and introduces him to Georgette Magritte.

1979—He undertakes the publication of a study devoted to René Magritte. He meets Susan Minas, who will become his wife, and travels to London, Italy, and Canada. The painter Vandycke convinces him to become a lecturer at the Advanced Institute for Visual and Figurative Arts in Mons, Belgium. He organizes various seminars devoted to the study of Heideggerian thought.

1980—He divides his time between Brussels and Paris.

1981—Publishes a work for bibliophiles on Magritte entitled *The Philosophy and the Painting of René Magritte*. He gives a series of lectures on the theme of "phenomena and language" at the La Cambre School of Art in Brussels. Delivers his first conference on the idea of "density" during a colloquium in Canada on Nietzsche. This text is translated into English by Zygmunt Adamczewski.

1982—He writes a novel, "Reality Strikes" ("Un Coup du Reel"), and a play, "Abstract Eros," both of which are unpublished. He publishes in Paris and in Milan a short study on the photographs of Magritte, as well as a book devoted to Paul Delvaux.

1983—He meets Fernando Botero. He gives first lecture in English: "The Issue of Fanaticism." He starts writing a yet unfinished work entitled "Who is Man?"

1984—He moves to Canada and gives various lectures there: "Hegel and the End of Philosophy," "Aristotle's Concept of *ηραγμα*," Botero's paintings, and "What is Wisdom?" He gives a course on Hegel and Marx at Brock University.

1985—He decides to end his academic career and devote himself to publishing a *Philosophic Encyclopedia of Contemporary Painting*. He travels to Colombia, writes the presentation for a Botero exhibit on the theme of the bullfight at the Marlborough Gallery in New York.

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Saturne et Jupiter (Saturn and Jupiter). Paris: Editions de la Différence, 1977.

L'Ossuaire de l'Esprit (Catacombs of the Mind). Paris: Editions de la Différence, 1977.

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La Philosophie et la Peinture de René Magritte. Paris: Editions Art 204, 1980. (English edition: *The Philosophy and the Painting of René Magritte*, New York.)

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Magritte et l'éclipse de l'être (Magritte and the Eclipse of Being). Paris: Editions de la Différence, 1982.

Paul Delvaux, l'essence de la peinture (Paul Delvaux, the Essence of Painting). Paris: Editions de la Différence, 1982.

Botero ou la plénitude de la forme (Botero or the Fullness of Form). Paris: L'Autre Musée—La Différence, 1983.



113. *The Bachelor*, 1974, 194 x 129
cm, oil on canvas.

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114. *Self-Portrait with Madame de Pompadour*, 1969, 244 x 165 cm, oil on canvas.

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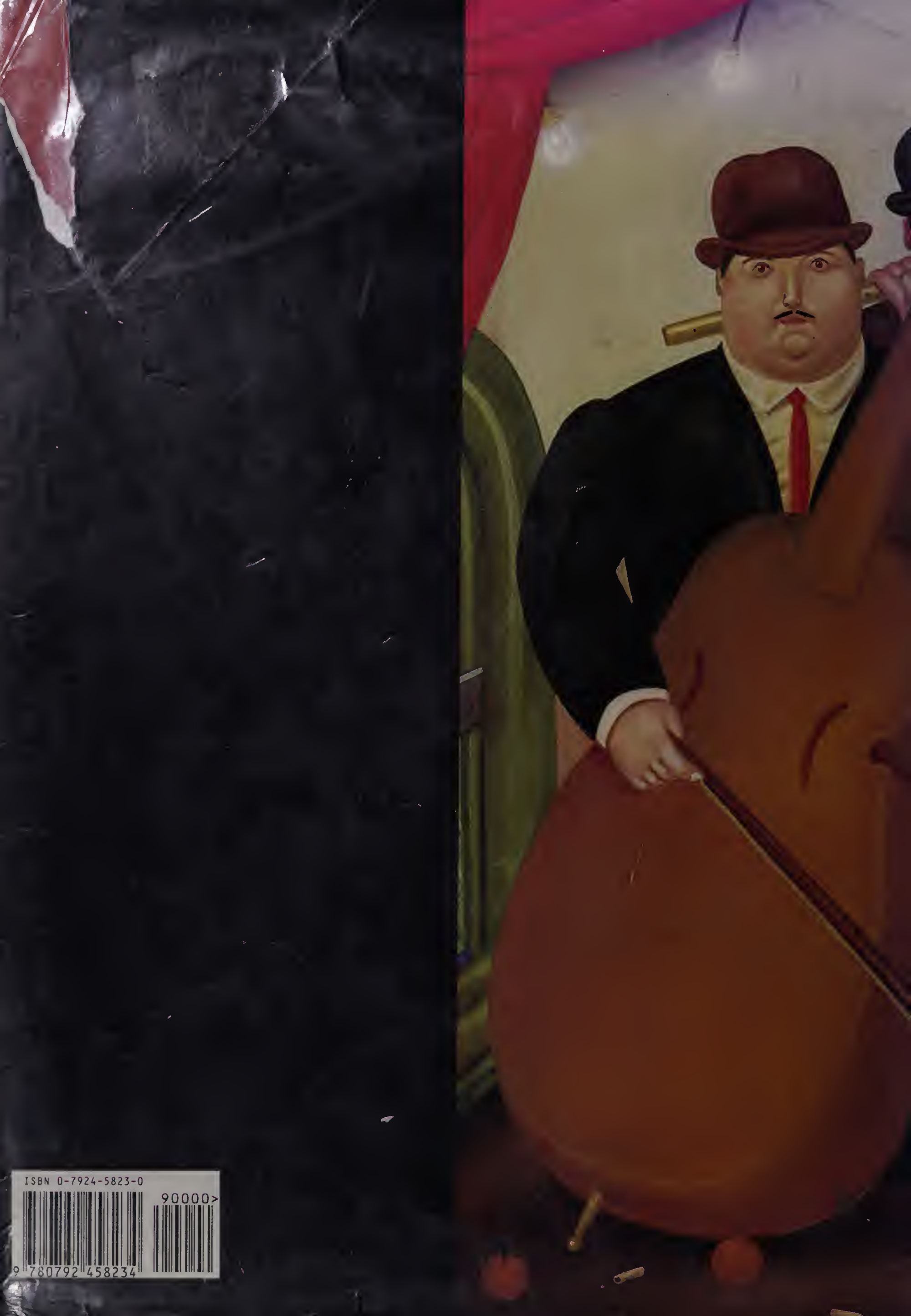
116. *Still Life*, 1969, 54 x 190 cm,
oil on canvas.

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